LIBERALIST CENTRE

F(in)AR

FREEDOM IN AFRICA REPORT

2026

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About F(in)AR 2026

The Freedom in Africa Report (F(in)AR) is a flagship research initiative of the Liberalist Centre, an African policy and research organisation.

F(in)AR 2026 is the second edition of the report, building on the foundation of the inaugural F(in)AR 2025. The first edition established a new framework for examining freedom and prosperity across Africa, bringing together evidence on political rights, economic opportunities and the conditions that shape people's well-being. The 2026 edition continues this work while expanding the evidence base and providing a new assessment of how these conditions are changing across the continent.

The report was created in response to the need for a stronger African perspective on freedom. While international indices provide valuable information on democracy, governance, rights and economic conditions, they do not always capture the distinct political, institutional and social realities found across African countries. F(in)AR brings these areas together to provide a broader understanding of how freedom and prosperity are experienced across the continent.

F(in)AR examines three interconnected dimensions: Political Freedom, Economic Freedom and Prosperity. Looking at these areas together provides a better picture of the environment in which people exercise their rights, participate in society, pursue economic opportunities and improve their quality of life.

With each edition, F(in)AR aims to build a consistent record of change across Africa. The 2026 report therefore serves both as an assessment of current conditions and as part of a longer-term effort to track progress, identify setbacks and draw attention to areas requiring further reform.

Rather than treating country rankings as a competition or a final judgement, F(in)AR uses comparative evidence to identify patterns, differences and areas of progress. The findings can help reveal where institutions are becoming stronger, where opportunities are expanding and where significant challenges continue to affect people's freedom and prosperity.

F(in)AR collects and standardises publicly available information from reputable international sources before interpreting the findings within an African context. By bringing these different datasets together, the report seeks to make complex information easier to understand while providing a consistent basis for examining change from one edition to the next.

What F(in)AR Seeks to Achieve

- Track changes in freedom and prosperity across African countries using consistent measures.
- Show where progress and setbacks are occurring across the continent.
- Put international data into an African context that is easier for the public to understand.
- Provide evidence that can strengthen research, public discussion and policy decisions.

How F(in)AR Can Be Used

For governments and policymakers, F(in)AR can serve as a reference for identifying areas of strength and areas requiring attention.

Changes in Political Freedom may highlight developments in elections, civic participation, judicial independence or the protection of civil rights. Economic Freedom indicators can reveal barriers affecting businesses, workers, investment and economic activity, while Prosperity indicators provide a broader view of the outcomes experienced by citizens.

For researchers, journalists and civil society organisations, the report provides a structured body of evidence for examining developments within and across African countries. Its findings can support research, reporting, advocacy and public discussion.

For citizens, F(in)AR offers a clearer way to understand the conditions shaping freedom and prosperity in their countries and how these compare with developments elsewhere on the continent.

F(in)AR is ultimately intended to support informed discussion and not to make a final verdict. Since the work began with the 2025 edition, the 2026 report contributes to an ongoing record of Africa's progress, challenges and changing freedom landscape.

Acknowledgements

The Liberalist Centre gratefully recognises the support of Atlas Network in strengthening the organisation's institutional and operational capacity. This support contributed to the Centre's ability to undertake and develop research initiatives such as the Freedom in Africa Report.

The findings, analysis and conclusions presented in F(in)AR 2026 remain the responsibility of the Liberalist Centre. The Centre maintains full editorial independence over the report and its contents.

The Liberalist Centre also extends its appreciation to the members of the team whose research, analysis, coordination and editorial contributions supported the development of this edition.

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Methodology

The Freedom in Africa Report (F[in]AR 2026) provides a comparative assessment of conditions across African countries by examining three broad areas: Political Freedom, Economic Freedom, and Prosperity.

These dimensions when considered together provide a wider picture of how political rights, economic conditions, and living standards interact in shaping the experience of freedom across the continent.

F[in]AR 2026 is based entirely on secondary data. Rather than generating its own surveys or collecting information directly from countries, the report uses established international and African datasets, indexes, and statistical sources. The indicators were selected based on their relevance to the three F[in]AR dimensions, their availability across African countries, and the credibility and consistency of the organisations responsible for producing the data.

For this edition, the assessment primarily uses the most recent data reported for 2026. Where a 2026 figure was not yet available, the latest available data from 2025 was used instead. This approach allows the report to incorporate the newest information available while avoiding the use of estimates where reliable, published figures were not yet available.

Because the original datasets use different scales, units, and scoring systems, the values were first standardised into a common 0–10 scale. This makes indicators from different sources directly comparable within the F[in]AR framework. Higher scores represent stronger performance on the relevant indicator, while lower scores indicate weaker performance.

The standardised indicator scores were organised under the three FinAR dimensions:

- **Political Freedom (POL)** — measures political participation, civil rights, institutional independence, free expression, assembly, and protection from political repression.

- **Economic Freedom (ECO)** — examines the conditions that allow individuals and businesses to participate in economic activity, including property rights, business conditions, trade, taxation, labour, mobility, and the digital economy.

- **Prosperity (PRO)** — considers the extent to which political and economic conditions translate into better living standards, including income, employment, education, healthcare, infrastructure, equality, and peace and stability.

Each country's performance across the relevant indicators was used to produce its score for each dimension. The three dimension scores were then brought together to produce the country's overall F[in]AR score. The final score is presented on a 0–100 scale, making the results easier to interpret and compare across countries.

To ensure that the overall assessment reflects all three components of the framework, the dimensions receive approximately equal weighting:

- Political Freedom — 33%
- Economic Freedom — 33%
- Prosperity — 34%

The overall score is therefore derived using the following formula:

Overall Score (0–100) = ((POL × 0.33) + (ECO × 0.33) + (PRO × 0.34)) × 10

Interpretation and Limitations

FinAR 2026 is intended to provide a comparative view of freedom and prosperity, rather than serve as a complete measure of every political, economic, or social condition within each country.

Its purpose is to identify differences, patterns, and relationships across countries and regions using a consistent framework.

The report's findings are dependent on the quality, coverage, and methodology of the external datasets on which it is based. Differences in source definitions, reporting periods, country coverage, and update schedules can affect comparability. The use of 2026 data where available, and 2025 data where 2026 figures had not yet been reported also means that not every indicator represents the same reference year.

To improve consistency, the data were standardised before being incorporated into the F(in)AR scoring system, and the same scoring approach was applied across the countries covered by the report. Nevertheless, the resulting scores should be understood as index-based comparative measures, not precise measurements of freedom or wellbeing.

F(in)AR is also designed to develop over time. As new datasets are published and existing indicators improve, future editions may update the underlying data, refine the indicators, and strengthen the framework while maintaining the core objective of measuring the relationship between freedom, opportunity, and prosperity in Africa.



Executive Summary

The Freedom in Africa Report (F(in)AR) 2026 is the second edition of the Liberalist Centre's annual assessment of freedom and prosperity across Africa. Following the foundation established by the inaugural 2025 report, this edition examines how political rights, economic opportunity and living conditions are developing across the continent. It brings these dimensions together to show a central reality of Africa's development: progress in one area does not always translate into progress in another.

F(in)AR 2026 assesses countries across three pillars — Political Freedom, Economic Freedom and Prosperity. The results reveal an Africa of significant contrasts. Some countries are building stronger institutions, expanding economic opportunity and providing better conditions for their citizens, while others continue to face the combined effects of political restrictions, weak institutions, insecurity, limited economic opportunity and poor access to essential services.

The overall picture is therefore neither one of uniform progress nor universal decline. Instead, the data points to a continent moving in different directions at the same time.

84.2

Mauritius recorded the highest overall F(in)AR score in 2026, followed by Seychelles, Ghana, Cape Verde, Botswana and South Africa.

52.8

Africa's Political Freedom score increased from 49.4 in 2025 to 52.8 in 2026, reflecting improvements in several areas including electoral integrity, expression, association and institutional protections.

44.3

Economic Freedom declined, falling from 58.9 in 2025 to 44.3 in 2026, despite improvements in some areas, particularly business conditions, labor freedom and digital economic activity.

56.5

Prosperity increased from 50.2 in 2025 to 56.5 in 2026, although weaknesses in employment, inequality, healthcare, and peace and stability continued to weigh on the overall picture.

Key trends among regions

Southern Africa: The continent's top-performing cluster, led by Botswana (71.1), South Africa (70.3), and Namibia (65.8), though it faces persistent employment and civic freedom gaps.

West Africa: Showcases strong leaders like Ghana, Cape Verde, and Senegal, contrasted sharply by severe institutional instability and military rule across the Sahel.

East Africa: Displays the continent's widest internal gap. Seychelles and Mauritius lead overall, while South Sudan, Somalia, and Eritrea remain at the bottom.

North & Central Africa: North Africa sees Morocco and Tunisia easily outperforming conflict-ridden Libya and Sudan. Central Africa remains the most difficult regional environment overall.

A (Dis)connected Africa

Cross-border mobility and digital tools offer immense economic potential, but both face severe political bottlenecks:

- Physical Mobility: ECOWAS leads the continent with 100% mutual visa-free travel, followed by the EAC. However, strict visa restrictions continue to block continental trade and investment.
- Digital Access: Mobile technology generated $240 billion (7.8% of GDP) and supported 13 million jobs. Despite this, a massive 63% usage gap remains because smartphones and data are unaffordable for most citizens.
- Digital Repression: Digital freedom is actively shrinking. Access Now tracked 30 internet shutdowns across 15 countries, heavily damaging e-commerce, mobile payments, and civic participation.

Youth and the Changing Civic Landscape

Young Africans are bypassing traditional political parties to challenge corruption and bad governance through direct activism, forcing a critical choice for governments:

- Continental Crackdowns: State suppression is widespread, with police detaining protesters in at least 19 countries and using excessive force in 20.
- The Policy Choice: Governments must either create formal channels to include youth participation in democratic governance or risk increasingly confrontational instability.

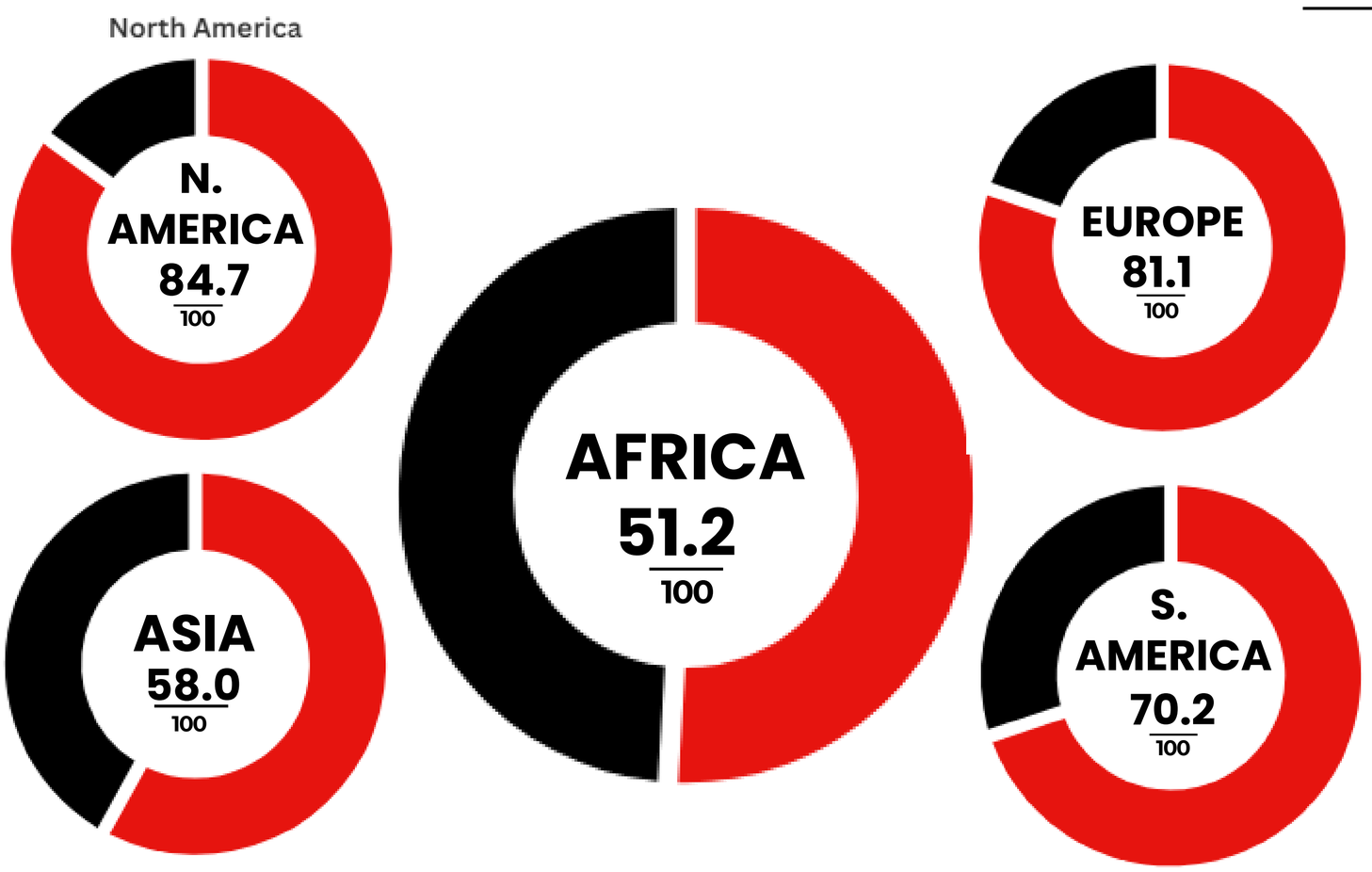
Policy Priorities

- Build Accountable Institutions: Strengthen the judiciary, electoral commissions, and oversight bodies so they function independently of whoever holds power.
- Ensure Credible Elections: Focus on transparent voter registration, campaign finance clarity, and trusted dispute resolution, rather than just holding votes.
- Protect Civic Space: Review and stop unlawful restrictions on assembly and journalism; independently investigate security forces using excessive force.
- Create Productive Jobs: Lower business startup costs, expand credit, and align vocational training with market realities to deliver stable, formal incomes for youth.
- Secure Property Rights: Modernize land registration and slash unnecessary bureaucratic licensing to boost investor confidence.
- Advance Practical Integration: Remove cross-border trade barriers under the AfCFTA and expand visa-free travel so Africans can seamlessly trade, study, and work.
- Maintain an Open Digital Economy: Classify internet access as an essential service, completely liberate political parties, and lower taxes on entry-level 4G & 5G smartphones.
- Anchor Growth in Prosperity: Measure national success by improvements in healthcare, education, social mobility, and standard of living.
- Prioritize Peace & Security: Invest heavily in conflict early-warning systems, security sector accountability, and local dispute resolution as foundations for recovery.
- Include Youth in Governance: Establish official youth councils and policy advisory boards to give the younger generation a legal voice outside of election cycles.





Freedom in Africa



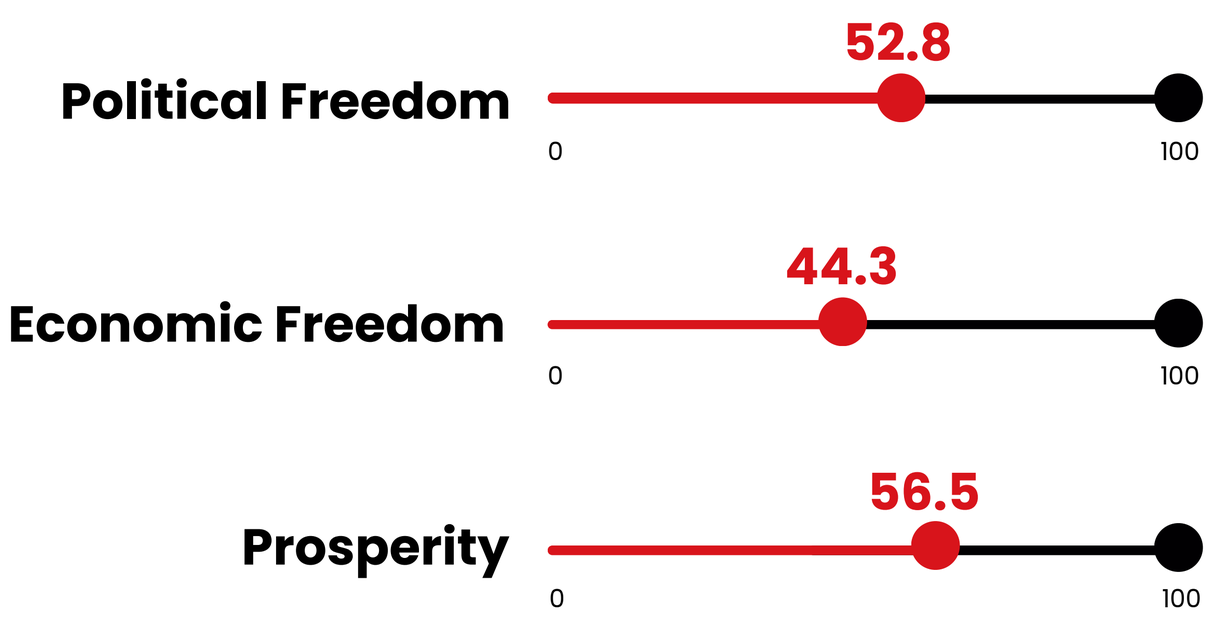
2026

Africa remains a highly challenging environment for human liberty and dignity, scoring 51.2 on the aggregate scale with a stark, visible divide between a slightly more open Sub-Saharan region and a heavily restricted North and Central Africa.

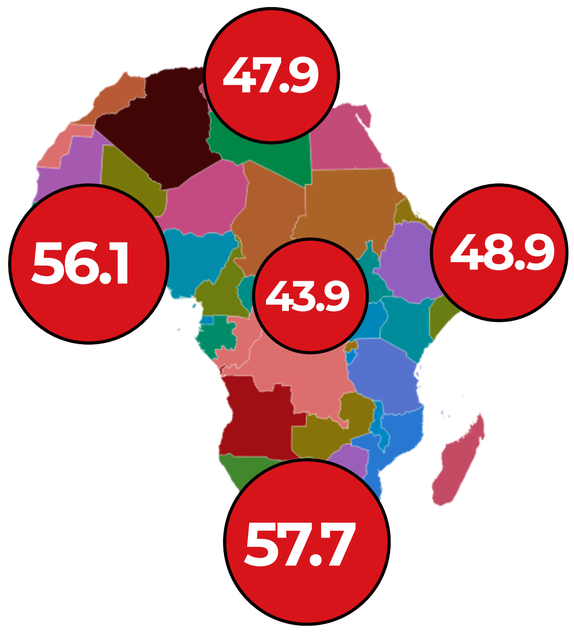
This partly free to not free status contrasts sharply with the rest of the world, where South America occupies a relatively stable middle ground at 70.2 and Asia sits at a heavily restricted 58.0 due to massive gaps between East and Central Asia.

Meanwhile, North America (84.7) and Europe (81.1) continue to lead the globe as the most highly free regions, continuously anchored by top global performers like Switzerland and Denmark.

Source: Freedom House (Freedom in the World) and the Cato Institute (Human Freedom Index).



Africa's overall progress is split across the varying indicators, with Political Freedom (52.8) leading slightly ahead of Economic Freedom (44.3) and Prosperity (56.5). These numbers show that while political and voting rights are slowly advancing, converting those gains into economic freedom and real, everyday prosperity for citizens remains a major challenge.



Southern Africa (57.7) and West Africa (56.1) lead the continent as the strongest and most open areas, driven by robust integration networks. Conversely, East Africa (48.9), North Africa (47.9), and Central Africa (43.9) lag significantly behind, remaining heavily insulated due to tighter civic boundaries, conflict, and restrictive travel rules.

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1.0

Political Freedom



1.1 Electoral Integrity

Africa's electoral landscape presents a mixed but broadly improving picture in 2026.

Elections serve as a central test of national political freedom. Their true integrity depends not only on the right of citizens to vote, but also on whether the process is fair, free from intimidation, and open to inclusive competition.

Several countries recorded notable gains, with Ghana rising from 6.8 to 9.5, Morocco from 2.9 to 7.9, and Côte d'Ivoire from 1.8 to 6.0. These nations emerged as the strongest performers in the dataset. Conversely, the picture is less encouraging at the bottom, where countries like Somalia and Libya continue to decline.

International IDEA classifies Ghana as a resilient democracy, highlighting its robust electoral administration and reliable dispute-resolution mechanisms.

However, broader analysis from IDEA warns that electoral integrity remains under severe pressure elsewhere in Africa, with manipulated outcomes and eroding public trust posing deep challenges.

Ultimately, while several African democracies show clear progress, electoral integrity across the wider continent remains fragile.

Figure 1. **Electoral Integrity Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Cape Verde	9.6	9.5 → 9.6
Ghana	9.5	6.8 → 9.5
Gambia	9	7.7 → 9
Lesotho	9	8.6 → 9
Seychelles	8.7	9.6 → 8.7
Malawi	8.6	8.1 → 8.6
Mauritius	8.6	5.5 → 8.6
South Africa	8.5	7.2 → 8.5
Sao Tome and Principe	8.4	8.8 → 8.4
Botswana	7.9	7.1 → 7.9
Kenya	7.9	4.7 → 7.9
Morocco	7.9	2.9 → 7.9
Liberia	7.4	8.2 → 7.4
Namibia	7.4	7.2 → 7.4
Guinea-Bissau	7.1	8.1 → 7.1
Niger	6.8	4.1 → 6.8
Senegal	6.8	6.8 → 6.8
Tunisia	6.8	4.6 → 6.8
Burkina Faso	6.3	4.1 → 6.3
Benin	6.2	4.5 → 6.2
Ivory Coast	6	1.8 → 6
Ethiopia	5.7	2.7 → 5.7
Sudan	5.5	5.5
Gabon	5.4	2.9 → 5.4
Nigeria	5.4	4.3 → 5.4
Djibouti	5.2	2.6 → 5.2
Angola	5	4.4 → 5
Zambia	5	5.3 → 5
Mali	4.9	1 → 4.9
Togo	4.9	3.8 → 4.9
Algeria	4.8	4.1 → 4.8
Madagascar	4.6	6.5 → 4.6
Sierra Leone	4.6	6.3 → 4.6
DR Congo	4.3	3.1 → 4.3
Uganda	3.9	2.4 → 3.9
Central African Republic	3.7	2.5 → 3.7
Guinea	3.7	1.9 → 3.7
Mozambique	3.7	2.9 → 3.7
Cameroon	3.4	2 → 3.4
Mauritania	3.4	5.8 → 3.4
Congo Republic	3.3	1.4 → 3.3
Eswatini	2.9	2.3 → 2.9
Comoros	2.8	→ 2.8
Egypt	2.7	1.3 → 2.7
Tanzania	2.6	3 → 2.6
Chad	2.3	→ 2.3
Zimbabwe	2.3	2.9 → 2.3
Burundi	2.2	1.7 → 2.2
Rwanda	2.2	4 → 2.2
Equatorial Guinea	2.1	2 → 2.1
South Sudan	2.1	→ 2.1
Eritrea	0.1	
Libya	0.1	→ 1
Somalia	0.1	→ 2.6

2025 2026

5.2

1.2 Freedom of Speech

The 2026 figures reveal a widening gap between African countries. In some countries, citizens enjoy relatively strong freedom to express themselves and their views

In others that privilege remains heavily constrained.

The Gambia recorded one of the most notable improvements, moving from 5.8 to 8.7.

This reflects improvements in the country's media environment including reduced journalist self-censorship and improved space for critical reporting.

However, the progress remains uneven as authorities in Gabon recently suspended access to major social-media platforms, prompting an urgent appeal from the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights.

Mauritius, Seychelles and Kenya also strengthened their positions. But on the other end, Eritrea scores just 0.1. The RSF says all independent media have been banned there since 2001, leaving information largely under government control.

Chad, Eswatini and Egypt also recorded substantial declines.

Figure 2. **Speech Freedom Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Ghana	9.6	10 → 9.6
Mauritius	9.5	7.3 → 9.5
Seychelles	9.5	7.5 → 9.5
Cape Verde	9.1	10 → 9.1
Kenya	9.1	7.5 → 9.1
Namibia	9.1	7.5 → 9.1
Sao Tome and Principe	9	10 → 9
Liberia	8.8	7.5 → 8.8
Nigeria	8.8	7.5 → 8.8
Sierra Leone	8.8	7.5 → 8.8
South Africa	8.8	10 → 8.8
Gambia	8.7	5.8 → 8.7
Senegal	8.6	7.1 → 8.6
Botswana	8.3	7.5 → 8.3
Gabon	8.2	4.7 → 8.2
Lesotho	8.2	7.2 → 8.2
Niger	7.9	6.7 → 7.9
Zambia	7.8	4.6 → 7.8
Benin	7.7	10 → 7.7
Malawi	7.7	7.5 → 7.7
Ivory Coast	7.2	6.9 → 7.2
Tunisia	6.5	8.5 → 6.5
Central African Republic	6.1	→ 6.1
Madagascar	6.1	6.9 → 6.1
Djibouti	6	5 → 6
Mauritania	5.8	4.8 → 5.8
Tanzania	5.8	2.1 → 5.8
Morocco	5.7	4.7 → 5.7
Somalia	5.4	2.5 → 5.4
Angola	5.2	5.2 → 5.2
Cameroon	5.1	2.1 → 5.1
Comoros	5.1	4.7 → 5.1
Mozambique	5	4.6 → 5
Guinea-Bissau	4.9	7.5 → 4.9
Mali	4.8	6 → 4.8
Togo	4.6	5 → 4.6
Guinea	4.5	4.8 → 4.5
Libya	4	2.2 → 4
Uganda	3.9	5 → 3.9
Algeria	3.8	4.8 → 3.8
Burkina Faso	3.8	5.6 → 3.8
DR Congo	3.7	2.1 → 3.7
Zimbabwe	3.5	2.2 → 3.5
Ethiopia	2.9	2.9 → 2.9
Sudan	2.8	3.2 → 2.8
Congo Republic	2.6	2.9 → 2.6
Chad	2.5	5 → 2.5
Rwanda	1.7	→ 1.7
Burundi	1.2	1 →
Egypt	1.2	2.1 →
Eswatini	0.9	2.1 →
Equatorial Guinea	0.7	→
South Sudan	0.7	→
Eritrea	0.1	

2025 2026

5.7

1.3 Press Freedom

A free press provides one of the most important checks on public power. The ability of journalists to investigate, publish and criticize those in authority is a key determining factor to society's broader freedom.

The 2026 data places several countries in a relatively strong position. with Namibia, South Africa, Ghana and Seychelles maintained all attaining good scores.

But stronger scores do not necessarily mean journalists are free from political, legal or economic pressure.

In South Africa for example, The RSF notes that despite the strong investigative media culture in the country, it is still burdened by verbal attacks on journalists by political figures.

Ghana's improvement similarly does not remove concerns surrounding journalist safety and media independence in the country.

At the opposite end, Eritrea remained one of the continent's weakest performers at just 1.3, despite a modest increase from 0.7.

The overall pattern sees press freedom gaining sufficient ground in parts of Africa, but political pressure, intimidation and restrictions on independent journalism continue to define the media environment.

Figure 3. **Press Freedom Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
South Africa	9.6	8.7 → 9.6
Namibia	9.5	9.1 → 9.5
Seychelles	9.1	9.1 → 9.1
Ghana	9	7.2 → 9
Cape Verde	8.9	8.3 → 8.9
Gabon	8.7	6.2 → 8.7
Mauritius	8.7	7.3 → 8.7
Gambia	8.6	8.1 → 8.6
Ivory Coast	8.3	7.7 → 8.3
Liberia	8	6.8 → 8
Mauritania	7.9	6.8 → 7.9
Botswana	7.8	6.7 → 7.8
Congo Republic	7.6	6 → 7.6
Comoros	7.5	6 → 7.5
Malawi	7.5	6.7 → 7.5
Senegal	7.3	6.9 → 7.3
Zambia	7.3	5.9 → 7.3
Sierra Leone	7.1	7.5 → 7.1
Central African Republic	7	6.2 → 7
Lesotho	6.8	6.1 → 6.8
Chad	6.6	5.4 → 6.6
Equatorial Guinea	6.5	3.3 → 6.5
Mozambique	6.5	5.4 → 6.5
Togo	6.5	6.5 → 6.5
Eswatini	6.4	4 → 6.4
Guinea-Bissau	6.4	6 → 6.4
Kenya	6.3	6.2 → 6.3
Madagascar	6.3	5.9 → 6.3
Morocco	6.3	4.5 → 6.3
Angola	6	5 → 6
Burkina Faso	6	7.2 → 6
Guinea	6	5.8 → 6
Nigeria	6	5 → 6
Benin	5.9	5.4 → 5.9
Burundi	5.8	4.2 → 5.8
Niger	5.8	6.7 → 5.8
South Sudan	5.8	3.5 → 5.8
Tanzania	5.8	5.2 → 5.8
Mali	5.7	5.8 → 5.7
Zimbabwe	5.5	4.6 → 5.5
Somalia	5.4	4.4 → 5.4
DR Congo	5.3	5 → 5.3
Uganda	5.2	4.5 → 5.2
Cameroon	5	4.3 → 5
Libya	5	4.2 → 5
Tunisia	5	6.5 → 5
Rwanda	4.9	3.5 → 4.9
Algeria	4.7	3.9 → 4.7
Ethiopia	4.3	4.6 → 4.3
Sudan	3.7	3.8 → 3.7
Djibouti	3.2	2.7 → 3.2
Egypt	3.1	2.1 → 3.1
Eritrea	1.3	1.3 →
Sao Tome and Principe		

2025 2026

6.4

1.4 Freedom of Association & Assembly

Freedom of assembly is a fundamental part of civic life. It determines whether people can gather peacefully, organize around shared concerns, protest government decisions or demand change without facing excessive state interference.

The African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR) recognizes peaceful assembly as a fundamental right under the African Charter, stressing that any restrictions should be lawful, necessary and proportionate.

Across Africa, however, the space to gather and demonstrate remains sharply divided. In some countries, restrictions on public demonstrations and political gatherings continue to make collective action difficult. In others, citizens appear to have gained considerably more room to organize and make their voices heard.

Nigeria recorded one of the most significant improvements, while Madagascar and Lesotho also moved strongly upward. The Gambia, Kenya, Liberia, Sierra Leone and Zambia experienced notable gains as well, pointing to a wider expansion of civic space in various sectors of the continent.

These developments suggest movement in a positive direction, but the ability to assemble still remains closely tied to the political environment in each country.

Figure 4. **Association Freedom Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Ghana	9.6	7.2 → 9.6
Mauritius	9.6	9.7 → 9.6
Cape Verde	9.5	8.1 → 9.5
Lesotho	9.4	5 → 9.4
Namibia	9.4	6.9 → 9.4
South Africa	9.4	8.2 → 9.4
Botswana	9.2	8.9 → 9.2
Nigeria	9.1	2.5 → 9.1
Seychelles	9	9.2 → 9
Sierra Leone	9	2.2 → 9
Madagascar	8.8	2.4 → 8.8
Liberia	8.7	5.2 → 8.7
Kenya	8.6	3.8 → 8.6
Senegal	8.6	3.6 → 8.6
Gambia	8.4	4.3 → 8.4
Malawi	8.3	5.4 → 8.3
Sao Tome and Principe	8.3	8.8 → 8.3
Zambia	8.1	3.8 → 8.1
Benin	6.7	3.6 → 6.7
Angola	6.6	1.6 → 6.6
Ivory Coast	6.6	4.1 → 6.6
Tanzania	6.6	→ 6.6
Gabon	6.5	2.5 → 6.5
Niger	6.1	2.1 → 6.1
Morocco	5.9	2.8 → 5.9
Togo	5.7	→ 5.7
Mozambique	5.6	4.6 → 5.6
Comoros	5.4	→ 5.4
Guinea-Bissau	5.4	2.6 → 5.4
Libya	5.4	1.2 → 5.4
DR Congo	5.1	→ 5.1
Tunisia	5.1	5.2 → 5.1
Central African Republic	4.9	→ 4.9
Somalia	4.7	2.9 → 4.7
Congo Republic	4.6	→ 4.6
Guinea	4.5	→ 4.5
Zimbabwe	4.5	1.2 → 4.5
Mauritania	4.4	3.2 → 4.4
Chad	4.2	→ 4.2
Djibouti	4.2	→ 4.2
Uganda	4	1.6 → 4
Ethiopia	3.6	2.5 → 3.6
Cameroon	3.5	→ 3.5
Burkina Faso	3.3	5.1 → 3.3
Mali	3.3	4.1 → 3.3
Algeria	3.2	1.5 → 3.2
Sudan	2.5	1.2 → 2.5
Burundi	2.3	→ 2.3
Equatorial Guinea	1.7	→ 1.7
Egypt	1.6	→ 1.6
South Sudan	1.5	→ 1.5
Rwanda	1.4	→ 1.4
Eritrea	0.1	→
Eswatini	0.1	→

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5.8

1.5 Judicial Independence

Judicial independence moved in varying directions across Africa in 2026.

Seychelles recorded the strongest score in the dataset, rising from 9.0 to 9.9.

Seychelles' improvement comes as its judiciary actively examines safeguards for its independence.

In 2025, the Judiciary of Seychelles held a symposium focused specifically on judicial independence, including reforms concerning impartiality, financial autonomy and judicial appointments.

The Gambia improved from 7.0 to 8.1 and Benin from 4.9 to 7.8. São Tomé and Príncipe and Tanzania also made notable gains.

By contrast, Nigeria shows a sharper deterioration, dropping from 6.1 to 2.9.

Freedom House reports that although judicial independence is constitutionally protected in the country, political interference, and corruption remain significant obstacles.

The broader pattern is one of divergence: while some countries strengthened others saw substantial declines, suggesting that constitutional guarantees alone do not ensure courts can operate independently.

Stronger reforms are needed before countries across Africa can achieve genuinely independent judiciaries.

Figure 5. **Independent Judiciary Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Seychelles	9.9	9 → 9.9
Botswana	8.3	7.9 → 8.3
Namibia	8.3	8.5 → 8.3
Cape Verde	8.1	8.8 → 8.1
Gambia	8.1	7 → 8.1
Mauritius	8	9.1 → 8
Benin	7.8	4.9 → 7.8
Sao Tome and Principe	7.5	5.5 → 7.5
Lesotho	7.3	6.5 → 7.3
Tanzania	7.2	5.5 → 7.2
Senegal	7	6.1 → 7
South Africa	7	8.9 → 7
Zambia	6.6	6.1 → 6.6
Kenya	6.5	6.8 → 6.5
Tunisia	6	5.2 → 6
Niger	5.8	4.6 → 5.8
Ghana	5.7	7 → 5.7
Malawi	5.7	7.9 → 5.7
Sierra Leone	5.4	5.8 → 5.4
Morocco	5.3	6.3 → 5.3
Burkina Faso	4.9	6 → 4.9
Gabon	4.2	3.8 → 4.2
Mali	4.2	4.8 → 4.2
Ivory Coast	4	4.2 → 4
Angola	3.8	3.1 → 3.8
Rwanda	3.8	3.8 → 3.8
Liberia	3.6	4.6 → 3.6
Egypt	3.2	3 → 3.2
Ethiopia	3.2	3.1 → 3.2
DR Congo	3	2.6 → 3
Mozambique	2.9	4.7 → 2.9
Nigeria	2.9	6.1 → 2.9
Algeria	2.5	2.1 → 2.5
Eswatini	2.2	3.5 → 2.2
Togo	2.1	4.4 → 2.1
Uganda	2.1	5.9 → 2.1
Congo Republic	1.8	2.3 → 1.8
Zimbabwe	1.8	3.4 → 1.8
Comoros	1.7	1.9 → 1.7
Guinea-Bissau	1.7	3.9 → 1.7
Somalia	1.7	1.7
Sudan	1.7	1.7 → 1.7
Madagascar	1.5	3.9 → 1.5
Central African Republic	1.2	3.1 → 1.2
Libya	1.2	2.0 → 1.2
Mauritania	1.1	4.1
Djibouti	1	3.1 → 1
Guinea	1	3.2 → 1
Burundi	0.8	1.7
Cameroon	0.8	1.4
South Sudan	0.7	1.5
Eritrea	0.6	1.2
Equatorial Guinea	0.4	1
Chad	0.1	1.5

2025 2026

4.0

1.6 Right to Dignity

Protection from torture and oppressive treatment is a fundamental test of how the state treats people in its custody and under its authority.

It encompasses protection from arbitrary or degrading treatment, particularly for detainees and other people who are especially vulnerable to abuses of state power.

The 2026 figures raise serious concerns in several countries, with Egypt recording the highest decline.

The United Nations Committee Against Torture has raised concerns about Egypt, including allegations of torture and ill-treatment in places of detention, and has called for stronger safeguards to prevent such abuses.

Chad, Eritrea, Eswatini, Libya and Angola also recorded substantial drops, pointing to a weakening of protections against coercion and abuse.

The movement was not uniformly negative. Ghana advanced from 8.1 to 9.5, while São Tomé and Príncipe reached 9.9. South Africa rose to 8.6 and Somalia made a notable recovery, increasing from 1.7 to 5.6.

The divide is consequential: while some states appear to be strengthening protections against abuse, others continue to show serious weaknesses in safeguarding people from oppression and torture.

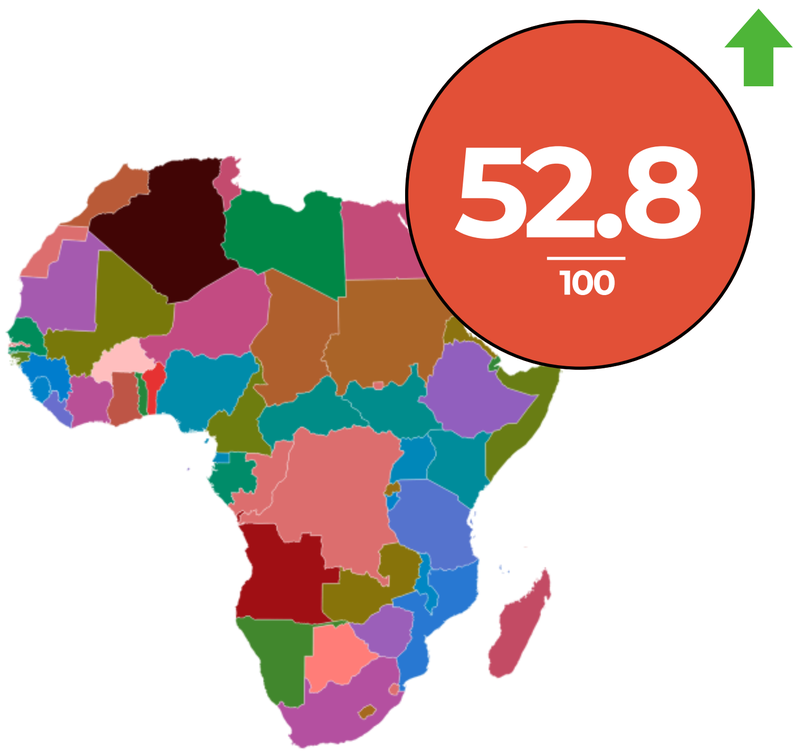
Figure 6. **Right to Dignity Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Sao Tome and Principe	9.9	9.5 → 9.9
Ghana	9.5	8.1 → 9.5
Cape Verde	8.7	9.9 → 8.7
Seychelles	8.7	10 → 8.7
South Africa	8.6	6.8 → 8.6
Mauritius	8.1	9.1 → 8.1
Gambia	7.9	9.5 → 7.9
Lesotho	7.9	8.8 → 7.9
Botswana	7.8	9.8 → 7.8
Malawi	7.2	9.1 → 7.2
Liberia	7.1	8.5 → 7.1
Namibia	6.7	9.2 → 6.7
Benin	6.5	7.7 → 6.5
Gabon	6.4	9.2 → 6.4
Morocco	6.4	8.7 → 6.4
Tanzania	6.3	8.3 → 6.3
Ivory Coast	6	8.7 → 6
Senegal	5.9	8.5 → 5.9
Sierra Leone	5.7	8.7 → 5.7
Kenya	5.6	5.4 → 5.6
Somalia	5.6	1.7 → 5.6
Zambia	5.3	8.7 → 5.3
Mali	4.9	1 → 4.9
Tunisia	4.8	8.6 → 4.8
Guinea-Bissau	4.7	9.3 → 4.7
Angola	4.2	8.2 → 4.2
Djibouti	3.9	8.5 → 3.9
Central African Republic	3.7	6 → 3.7
Algeria	3.6	8.4 → 3.6
Comoros	3.6	9.1 → 3.6
Madagascar	3.6	7.3 → 3.6
Togo	3.6	8.4 → 3.6
Niger	3.5	5.3 → 3.5
Burkina Faso	3.3	1.5 → 3.3
Mauritania	3.3	9.2 → 3.3
Nigeria	3.3	3.3
Ethiopia	3.1	2.2 → 3.1
Mozambique	3.1	5.1 → 3.1
Cameroon	2.9	2.9
Congo Republic	2.9	9.2 → 2.9
South Sudan	2.9	3.3 → 2.9
DR Congo	2.8	2.8
Guinea		
Rwanda		
Mali	3.3	4.1 → 3.3
Algeria	3.2	1.5 → 3.2
Sudan	2.5	1.2 → 2.5
Burundi	2.3	2.3
Equatorial Guinea	1.7	1.7
Egypt	1.6	1.6
South Sudan	1.5	1.5
Rwanda	1.4	1.4
Eritrea	0.1	
Eswatini	0.1	

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4.6

Political Freedom in Africa at a Glance



Political Freedom improved across Africa in 2026, with the continental score rising from 49.4 in 2025 to 52.8. The increase reflects stronger performance in elections, free expression, press freedom, assembly, judicial independence, and protection of rights.

Political freedom refers to the extent to which people can participate freely in public and political life without undue interference or repression.

It encompasses the ability to vote and choose leaders, express opinions, access independent media, organise and protest peacefully, and receive fair treatment from political and judicial institutions.

The index recorded a clear improvement in the 2026 dataset, with the overall average rising from 47 in 2025 to 52.8 in 2026. The gains across electoral integrity, freedom of speech, press freedom, freedom of assembly, judicial independence, and protection from oppression and torture suggest that the political liberty measure expanded in a number of African countries.

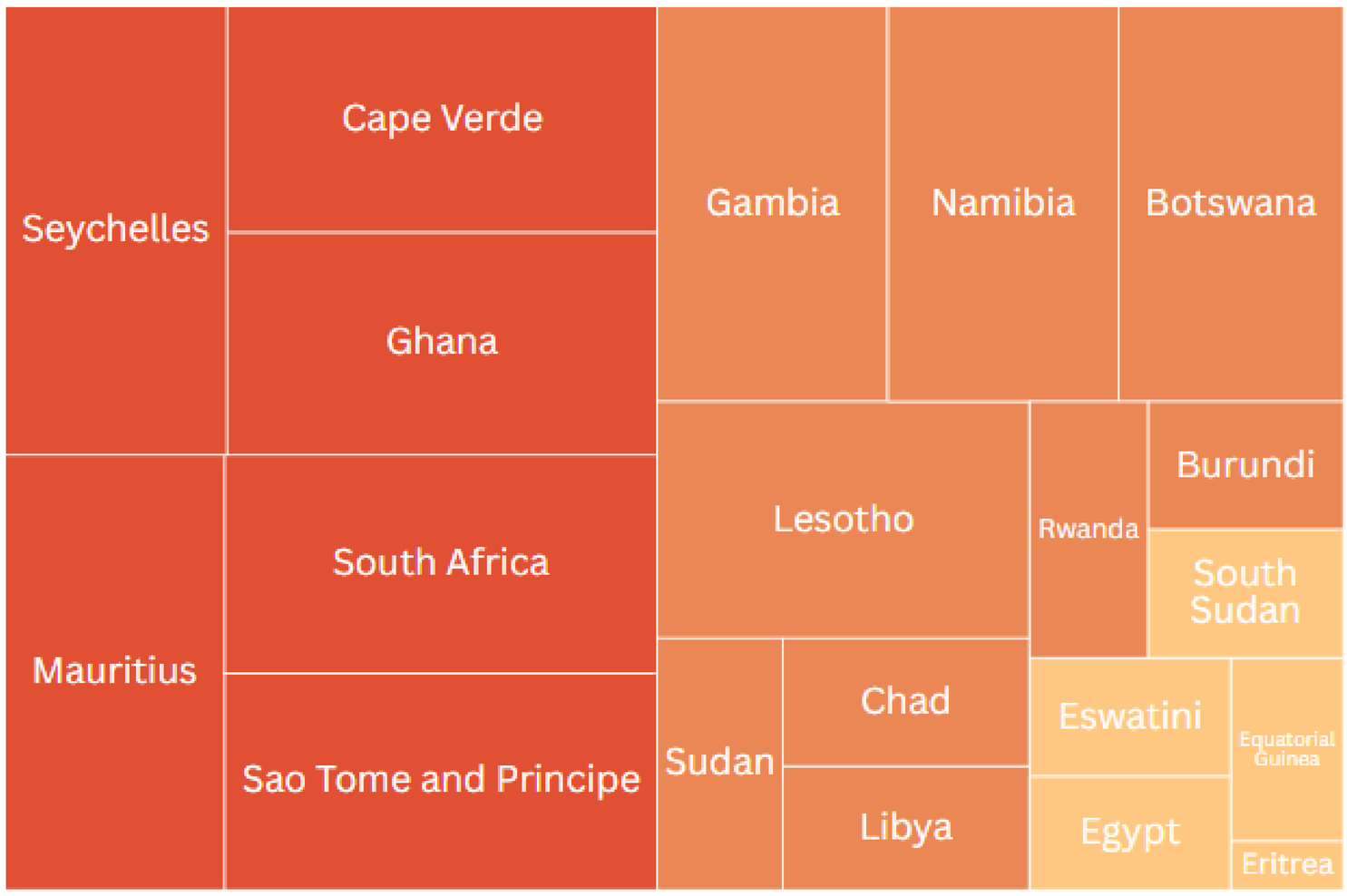
However, the improvement should not be interpreted as a continent-wide reversal of democratic decline. The individual indicators reveal substantial setbacks in countries such as Chad, Burundi, Cameroon, Egypt and Equatorial Guinea, while judicial independence remained especially uneven.

The International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (International IDEA) similarly identifies fragile institutions, electoral manipulation and human-rights abuses as continuing pressures on democratic consolidation in Africa.

Public demand for political freedoms also remains strong. Afrobarometer found that 65% of citizens surveyed across 38 African countries feel at least somewhat free to express their views, although that figure has declined over the longer term.

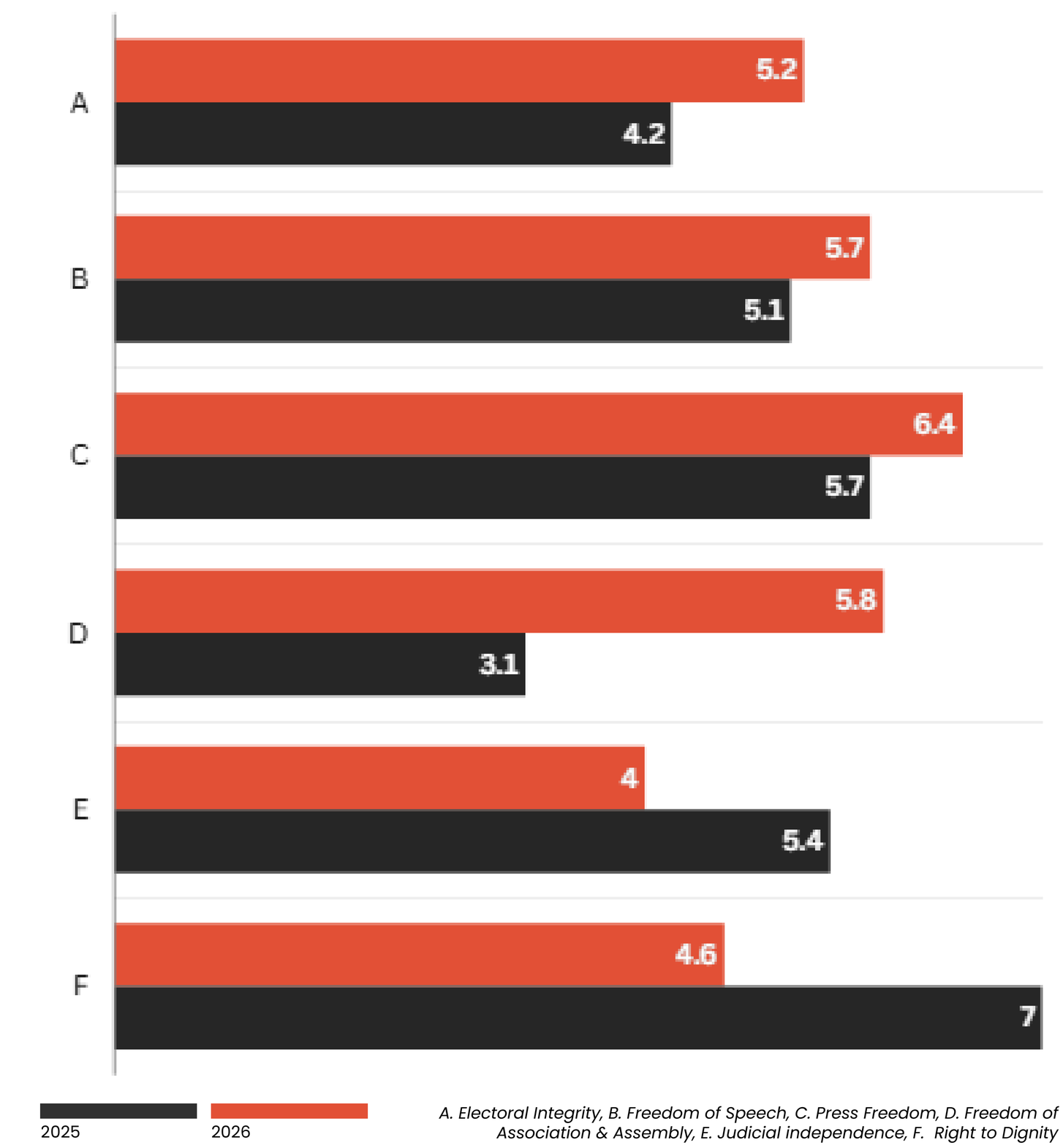
The 2026 outlook is therefore cautiously positive: Africa's political freedom score has improved, but the uneven country-level results show that democratic gains remain fragile and far from secure.

Figure 7. **Top 10 and Bottom 10 Country Scores, 2026**



The top 10 political performers are Seychelles (9.2), Cape Verde (9.0), Ghana (8.8), Mauritius (8.8), South Africa (8.7), São Tomé and Príncipe (8.6), Gambia (8.4), Namibia (8.4), Botswana (8.2), and Lesotho (8.1), while the bottom 10 are Sudan (2.9), Chad (2.9), Libya (2.8), Rwanda (2.8), Burundi (2.3), South Sudan (2.3), Eswatini (2.2), Egypt (2.1), Equatorial Guinea (1.9), and Eritrea (0.5).

Figure 8. **Side by side comparison of 2025 & 2026 Political Freedom Scores**



A. Electoral Integrity, B. Freedom of Speech, C. Press Freedom, D. Freedom of Association & Assembly, E. Judicial independence, F. Right to Dignity

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2.0

Economic Freedom



2.1 Property Rights

Property rights determine how securely individuals and businesses can own, use, transfer and invest in land and other assets.

When ownership is uncertain or difficult to enforce, people have less confidence to invest and businesses face greater risks.

The Property Rights Alliance, in its 2025 International Property Rights Index, placed Africa at the bottom of the regional rankings, with a score of 3.78.

It links stronger property-rights systems with greater investment, entrepreneurship and economic development.

The absence of these is reflected in the many economies (including Burkina Faso, Chad, Libya, Mali, Niger, and Somalia) that recorded substantial declines in property rights.

Research published by Cambridge University Press estimates that only around 15% of African households hold formal titles to their farmland, leaving many without fully documented tenure.

The result is a persistent gap between owning an asset in practice and having the legal security needed to protect that ownership.

Figure 9. **Property Rights Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Mauritius	9.6	8.6 → 9.6
Seychelles	9.5	8.3 → 9.5
Cape Verde	8.4	8.8 → 8.4
Botswana	8.2	9.2 → 8.2
Namibia	7.2	7.9 → 7.2
Rwanda	6.9	5.8 → 6.9
Senegal	6.5	7.2 → 6.5
Tunisia	6.4	7.9 → 6.4
Gambia	6.3	6.3 → 6.3
Morocco	6.3	7.2 → 6.3
Sao Tome and Principe	6.3	8 → 6.3
Ghana	5.7	7.2 → 5.7
South Africa	5.6	7 → 5.6
Benin	5.3	6.5 → 5.3
Tanzania	5.1	6 → 5.1
Ivory Coast	5	6 → 5
Togo	5	5.3 → 5
Zambia	5	5.3 → 5
Eswatini	4.9	2.7 → 4.9
Lesotho	4.8	7 → 4.8
Uganda	4.8	6.2 → 4.8
Kenya	4.6	6.4 → 4.6
Liberia	4.6	5.3 → 4.6
Madagascar	4.6	5.9 → 4.6
Angola	4.2	3.7 → 4.2
Egypt	4.1	5.4 → 4.1
Mauritania	3.8	4.6 → 3.8
Sierra Leone	3.8	4.8 → 3.8
Djibouti	3.4	4.9 → 3.4
Gabon	3.4	4.6 → 3.4
Mozambique	3.4	3.8 → 3.4
Nigeria	3.4	4.7 → 3.4
Congo Republic	3.3	4.3 → 3.3
Algeria	3.2	5.4 → 3.2
Cameroon	3.2	4.8 → 3.2
Guinea-Bissau	3.2	4.8 → 3.2
Burundi	3.1	3.9 → 3.1
Comoros	2.9	5.5 → 2.9
Ethiopia	2.5	3.9 → 2.5
Guinea	2.4	3.1 → 2.4
Zimbabwe	2.2	2.8 → 2.2
Burkina Faso	2.1	5.4 → 2.1
Chad	1.9	4.8 → 1.9
Equatorial Guinea	1.9	2.7 → 1.9
Niger	1.9	4.9 → 1.9
DR Congo	1.7	2 → 1.7
South Sudan	1.7	1.5 → 1.7
Mali	1.6	5.3 → 1.6
Sudan	0.8	2.3
Central African Republic	0.7	2.5
Libya	0.7	2.7
Eritrea	0.6	
Somalia	0.1	1

2025 2026

4.1

2.2 Ease of Starting a Business

Starting a business became easier in some African economies in 2026, but the improvements were far from widespread.

The World Bank's Business Ready framework assesses business entry through the quality of regulations, digital public services and transparency, and the time and cost required to register a company.

It notes that cumbersome start-up requirements discourage formal business startups, while simpler processes can support job creation and more private-sector growth.

Cabo Verde recorded the most striking improvement with 9.1 from 5.5 last, while Mauritius climbed to 9.6 and Morocco reached 7.9. Gabon, Côte d'Ivoire and South Africa also strengthened their positions.

At the other end, Somalia fell to 0.1, while Burundi, Chad, the Central African Republic and Sudan all recorded very low scores.

The contrast in this dataset is therefore significant. A few African countries appear increasingly supportive of new businesses, while several fragile economies remain difficult environments for formal enterprise.

With many countries moving backwards, the 2026 figures show that Africa's progress in business creation is highly unequal, with administrative barriers continuing to limit entrepreneurship in parts of the continent.

Figure 10. **Ease of Starting a Business Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Mauritius	9.6	8.2 → 9.6
Cape Verde	9.1	5.5 → 9.1
Morocco	7.9	7.9
Seychelles	7.7	6.2 → 7.7
Ivory Coast	7.2	6.1 → 7.2
South Africa	7.2	6.7 → 7.2
Ghana	6.7	6 → 6.7
Gabon	6.6	4.5 → 6.6
Botswana	6.2	6.6 → 6.2
Kenya	6.2	7.3 → 6.2
Rwanda	5.9	7.6 → 5.9
Sao Tome and Principe	5.9	4.5 → 5.9
Togo	5.9	6.2 → 5.9
Algeria	5.7	5.7
Tunisia	5.7	5.7
Namibia	5.5	6.2 → 5.5
Comoros	5	4.8 → 5
Senegal	5	5.9 → 5
Benin	4.7	5.2 → 4.7
Djibouti	4.7	4.7
Zambia	4.7	6.7 → 4.7
Egypt	4.4	4.4
Lesotho	4.4	5.9 → 4.4
Eswatini	4.2	6 → 4.2
Gambia	4.2	5 → 4.2
Nigeria	4.2	5.7 → 4.2
Uganda	4.2	6 → 4.2
Cameroon	4	4.6 → 4
Tanzania	3.8	5.5 → 3.8
Ethiopia	3.3	4.8 → 3.3
Guinea	3.3	4.9 → 3.3
Sierra Leone	3.3	4.8 → 3.3
Angola	3	4.1 → 3
Zimbabwe	2.8	5.5 → 2.8
Mali	2.7	5.3 → 2.7
Mozambique	2.5	5.5 → 2.5
Mauritania	2.3	5.2 → 2.3
Burkina Faso	2.1	5.1 → 2.1
Liberia	2.1	4.2 → 2.1
Madagascar	2	4.8 → 2
Congo Republic	1.8	3.9 → 1.8
Equatorial Guinea	1.8	4.1 → 1.8
Guinea-Bissau	1.6	4.3 → 1.6
South Sudan	1.6	3.5 → 1.6
Malawi	1.5	6 → 1.5
DR Congo	1.1	3.6 → 1.1
Libya	1.1	1.1
Niger	1.1	5.7 → 1.1
Eritrea	1	2.2 → 1
Burundi	0.3	4.7
Central African Republic	0.3	3.6
Chad	0.3	3.9
Sudan	0.3	4.5
Somalia	0.1	2

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3.8

2.3 Free Trade

Free Trade weakened across much of the 2026 dataset.

The World Bank reported in August 2026 that roughly 60% of Africa's trade costs come from barriers within countries themselves, including customs delays, inefficient logistics, regulatory differences and restrictions on transport and services.

It argues that reducing these domestic frictions is central to making the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) work in practice.

This challenge is particularly important because intra-African trade remains relatively limited. The United Nations Economic Commission for Africa (UNECA) says AfCFTA could help reduce commodity dependence, expand manufacturing and strengthen regional value chains, but only if countries implement the necessary reforms.

Against this backdrop, the 2026 scores suggest that Africa's trade environment remains uneven, with a few relatively open economies contrasting sharply with countries where border, regulatory and market restrictions continue to constrain commerce.

Mauritius remained the standout performer, while Kenya, Equatorial Guinea, and Chad, registered sizeable setbacks.

Figure 11. **Free Trade Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Mauritius	9.6	9.2 → 9.6
Seychelles	8.6	8.5 → 8.6
Botswana	7.9	8.3 → 7.9
Eswatini	7.4	7.9 → 7.4
Ivory Coast	7.4	7.6 → 7.4
Mozambique	6.9	7.6 → 6.9
Angola	6.8	7.2 → 6.8
Morocco	6.8	7.3 → 6.8
Namibia	6.8	7.7 → 6.8
Malawi	6.6	7.2 → 6.6
South Africa	6.6	7.6 → 6.6
DR Congo	6.4	7 → 6.4
Eritrea	6.4	7.2 → 6.4
Madagascar	6.4	7.1 → 6.4
Cape Verde	6.3	7 → 6.3
Senegal	6.3	6.9 → 6.3
Niger	6.1	6.6 → 6.1
Togo	6.1	6.9 → 6.1
Gambia	5.9	6.8 → 5.9
Ghana	5.9	6.6 → 5.9
Lesotho	5.9	6.8 → 5.9
Sao Tome and Principe	5.9	6.8 → 5.9

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Comoros	5.8	6.3 → 5.8
Mali	5.8	6.7 → 5.8
Nigeria	5.8	7 → 5.8
Sierra Leone	5.8	6.7 → 5.8
Benin	5.6	6.2 → 5.6
Zambia	5.6	7 → 5.6
Guinea	5.4	6.5 → 5.4
Rwanda	5.4	6.1 → 5.4
Burkina Faso	5.3	6.4 → 5.3
Egypt	5.1	6.6 → 5.1
Mauritania	5.1	6.5 → 5.1
Algeria	4.9	6.2 → 4.9
Tanzania	4.9	6.5 → 4.9
Uganda	4.8	6.4 → 4.8
Cameroon	4.6	5.8 → 4.6
Ethiopia	4.6	6.2 → 4.6
Gabon	4.6	5.8 → 4.6
Liberia	4.6	6.5 → 4.6
Tunisia	4.3	6.5 → 4.3
Congo Republic	3.9	5.7 → 3.9
Burundi	3.8	5.6 → 3.8
Kenya	3.8	6.1 → 3.8

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Djibouti	3.4	5 → 3.4
Zimbabwe	3.4	4.9 → 3.4
Central African Republic	3.1	4.9 → 3.1
Guinea-Bissau	2.9	5.5 → 2.9
Chad	2.8	5.1 → 2.8
Equatorial Guinea	2.4	5.1 → 2.4
Sudan	0.1	4.3
Libya		
Somalia		
South Sudan		

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5.4

2.4 Free Movement

Free movement is an important part of continental integration.

The African Union Commission's protocol on Free Movement of Persons seeks to give African citizens the rights to enter, reside, and establish themselves in other member states, although implementation has progressed slowly across the continent.

The 2026 results point to a more constrained mobility environment overall.

The disparity between countries shows that the freedom to travel, relocate and move freely within and across borders remains far from uniform in Africa.

Gambia declined from 9.5 to 8.7, Ghana from 9.1 to 7.2, and Benin from 9.1 to 7.3. The declines were broader in countries such as Nigeria, Namibia, Malawi and Mozambique. Eritrea, at just 0.1, recorded the lowest score.

There were exceptions to the downward trend. Seychelles improved from 8.7 to 9.6, while Mauritius also gained, reaching 7.4. These countries contrast with states where conflict, security concerns or restrictive government policies can significantly limit mobility.

Overall, freedom of movement weakened noticeably in 2026, with most countries recording lower scores than in 2025.

Figure 12. **Free Movement Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Seychelles	9.6	8.7 → 9.6
Gambia	8.7	9.5 → 8.7
Mauritius	7.4	6.8 → 7.4
South Africa	7.4	7.9 → 7.4
Benin	7.3	9.1 → 7.3
Ghana	7.2	9.1 → 7.2
Sao Tome and Principe	7.2	9.2 → 7.2
Cape Verde	7.1	8.9 → 7.1
Namibia	7	8.4 → 7
Senegal	7	9 → 7
Zambia	6.8	8.2 → 6.8
Botswana	6.5	7.9 → 6.5
Liberia	6.5	8.7 → 6.5
Malawi	6.2	7.8 → 6.2
Lesotho	5.8	7.2 → 5.8
Sierra Leone	5.8	7.5 → 5.8
Tanzania	5.8	6.9 → 5.8
Gabon	5.7	7.3 → 5.7
Niger	5.6	7 → 5.6
Nigeria	5.6	7.7 → 5.6
Tunisia	5.5	6.7 → 5.5
Mali	5.4	7.1 → 5.4

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Morocco	5.3	5.7 → 5.3
Togo	5.3	6.9 → 5.3
Guinea-Bissau	5.1	6.8 → 5.1
Angola	5	6.5 → 5
Madagascar	4.9	6 → 4.9
Kenya	4.7	5.5 → 4.7
Burkina Faso	4.5	6.1 → 4.5
Mauritania	4.4	5.4 → 4.4
Eswatini	4.3	4.3 → 4.3
Mozambique	4.1	5.6 → 4.1
Ivory Coast	4	5.6 → 4
Zimbabwe	4	5.4 → 4
Comoros	3.4	4.5 → 3.4
Algeria	3.3	4.1 → 3.3
Uganda	3	3.8 → 3
Cameroon	2.9	4.6 → 2.9
DR Congo	2.8	3.8 → 2.8
Egypt	2.3	2.3 → 2.3
Burundi	2	2.2 → 2
Somalia	2	2.9 → 2
Chad	1.9	2.2 → 1.9
Central African Republic	1.8	2.1 → 1.8

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Djibouti	1.6	2.2 → 1.6
Congo Republic	1.4	1.7 → 1.4
Libya	1.4	1.9 → 1.4
Sudan	1.4	1.7 → 1.4
Ethiopia	1.1	1.9
Equatorial Guinea	1	1 → 1
Guinea	0.7	1.4
Rwanda	0.7	
South Sudan	0.3	
Eritrea	0.1	

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4.4

2.5 Tax burden

The World Bank notes that improving tax administration and broadening the tax base can help governments raise revenue without placing excessive pressure on productive economic activity.

It has warned that when compliance is complicated or the tax base is too narrow, tax systems across Africa can place significant pressure on businesses and households

South Africa provides the clearest example for this. The OECD reports that South Africa's tax-to-GDP ratio reached 24.5% in 2023/24, higher than in most emerging economies, and is still expected to rise further.

The burden is also concentrated heavily on direct taxation. Personal income tax accounts for a larger share of South Africa's tax revenue than in the average African economy, while the corporate tax rate remains high.

South Africa was not alone in experiencing higher tax pressure. Senegal, Guinea-Bissau, São Tomé and Príncipe, Cape Verde, Cameroon, Ghana, Liberia and Uganda also recorded substantial increases.

This raises the need for governments in African countries to develop ways to sustain revenue without placing excessive pressure on households and businesses.

Figure 13. **Tax Burden Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Seychelles	7.7	4.6 7.7
Mauritius	6.5	6.5
Madagascar	6.5	6.5
Guinea	6.5	7 6.5
Nigeria	5.4	2.1 5.4
Gambia	5.2	4.3 5.2
Botswana	5.2	5.2
Angola	5.2	5.2
Egypt	4.6	1.7 4.6
Tanzania	3.9	3.6 3.9
Rwanda	3.9	3.9 3.9
Lesotho	3.9	5.7 3.9
Chad	3.9	9.6 3.9
Comoros	3.5	8.9 3.5
Central African Republic	3.5	8.5 3.5
Mozambique	3.4	5.6 3.4
Mali	3.2	7.3 3.2
Eswatini	3.2	4.7 3.2
Togo	3.1	7.3 3.1
Benin	3.1	7.3 3.1
Tunisia	2.6	5.4 2.6
Malawi	2.6	4.7 2.6

Location	Scores/10 ▼	Change from Last year
Kenya	2.6	4.2 2.6
Ghana	2.6	3.4 2.6
Gabon	2.6	4.7 2.6
Ethiopia	2.6	4.4 2.6
Equatorial Guinea	2.6	5.4 2.6
DR Congo	2.6	5.8 2.6
Algeria	2.6	5.8 2.6
Burundi	2.4	5.1 2.4
Niger	2.2	4.6 2.2
Zambia	2.1	6 2.1
Namibia	2.1	7.1 2.1
Eritrea	2	4.3 2
Morocco	1.9	7.3 1.9
Ivory Coast	1.9	4 1.9
Burkina Faso	1.9	3.2 1.9
Cameroon	1.8	5.8 1.8
Djibouti	1.7	3.4 1.7
Cape Verde	1.6	3.4
Uganda	1.4	5.5
Mauritania	1.4	4.9
Liberia	1.4	1.8
Congo Republic	1.4	5.2

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Sao Tome and Principe	1.2	
Zimbabwe	1.1	7.7
Guinea-Bissau	1.1	
Senegal	0.6	6.9
South Africa	0.1	8.7
Sudan		2.1
Sierra Leone		
South Sudan		
Somalia		
Libya		

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3.2

2.6 Labor Freedom

Nigeria recorded the strongest improvement in labor freedom among the major economies, followed by South Africa, which reached 8.8, and Mauritius, which climbed to 8.6. Burkina Faso and Cape Verde also made modest gains.

Labor freedom reflects how easily people can enter employment, change jobs and participate in the labor market, while also considering the flexibility available to employers. In economies where these conditions are weak, workers can face fewer opportunities while businesses may struggle to create and sustain jobs.

And Several countries faced these consequences. Ethiopia fell from 5.0 to 2.3, while Sudan dropped from 5.3 to 1.5 and Zimbabwe from 4.1 to 1.3. Somalia, at 0.1, remained at the bottom of the dataset.

Figure 14. **Labor Freedom Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Nigeria	9.6	8.6 9.6
South Africa	8.8	7.6 8.8
Mauritius	8.6	7.7 8.6
Namibia	7.2	7.8 7.2
Burkina Faso	7	6.6 7
Tanzania	7	7.1 7
Botswana	6.8	7.1 6.8
Benin	6.6	6.5 6.6
Cape Verde	6.6	6.1 6.6
Djibouti	6.2	5.9 6.2
Ivory Coast	6	6.1 6
Kenya	6	6.4 6
Lesotho	6	6.5 6
Comoros	5.8	6.4 5.8
Guinea	5.8	6 5.8
Guinea-Bissau	5.8	6.4 5.8
Madagascar	5.8	5.9 5.8
Tunisia	5.8	6.1 5.8
Uganda	5.8	7.1 5.8
Eswatini	5.7	6.6 5.7
Gabon	5.7	6.1 5.7
Ghana	5.7	6.4 5.7

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Malawi	5.7	6.5 5.7
Niger	5.7	5.8 5.7
Chad	5.5	5.7 5.5
DR Congo	5.5	5.7 5.5
Mali	5.5	6 5.5
Mauritania	5.5	6 5.5
Senegal	5.5	5.5 5.5
Algeria	5.1	5.8 5.1
Congo Republic	5.1	4.8 5.1
Seychelles	5.1	6.7 5.1
Togo	5.1	5.7 5.1
Angola	4.9	6.1 4.9
Burundi	4.7	5.7 4.7
Central African Republic	4.5	4.7 4.5
Rwanda	4.5	6.1 4.5
Zambia	4.5	5 4.5
Libya	4.3	3.2 4.3
Mozambique	4.3	5.2 4.3
Cameroon	3.9	5.3 3.9
Gambia	3.9	6 3.9
Morocco	3.9	4.9 3.9
Equatorial Guinea	3.7	4.8 3.7

The International Labour Organization (ILO) continues to identify informality as a major challenge for African workers. Its latest regional assessment estimates that roughly 86% of employment in Africa is informal, leaving many workers without adequate social protection, employment security or effective access to labor rights.

Labor freedom is expanding in some countries, but secure and flexible employment remains far from equally accessible across the continent.

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Egypt	3.3	4.6 3.3
Eritrea	3.3	6.2 3.3
Liberia	3.3	4.8 3.3
Sao Tome and Principe	2.9	4.8 2.9
Ethiopia	2.3	5 2.3
Sierra Leone	2.3	3.4 2.3
Sudan	1.5	5.3 1.5
Zimbabwe	1.3	4.1 1.3
Somalia	0.1	
South Sudan		

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5.1

2.7 Digital Economy Growth

Digital economic growth shows how effectively countries are using technology, connectivity and digital services to create new economic opportunities. Beyond internet access itself, a stronger digital economy can support entrepreneurship, improve productivity, expand financial inclusion, access to services and create new opportunities for businesses and workers.

The world bank Digital Economy for Africa initiative has focused particularly on expanding affordable internet access, digital skills, and innovation, although progress has varied considerably between countries.

Togo recorded the strongest performance. Ethiopia and Burkina Faso also made notable progress, while Ghana, Senegal, Uganda and Egypt strengthened their positions. These gains suggest that digital infrastructure, is becoming an increasingly important driver of growth in several African economies.

But the figures also expose major decline in some economies. Niger plunged from 6.4 to 0.1, while Lesotho fell from 6.9 to 2.5 and Cape Verde from 7.3 to 3.5. Rwanda, previously at 9.9, also declined to 7.3.

The result is a distinctly shows how Africa is expanding its digital economy, but the pace of transformation differs sharply from one country to another. Some countries are building stronger digital economies, while others risk falling further behind.

Figure 15. **Digital Economy Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year	Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Togo	9.6	7.5 9.6	Gabon	6.1	5.9 6.1
Ethiopia	8.7	6.5 8.7	Eswatini	5.8	4.8 5.8
Ghana	8.4	7.3 8.4	Nigeria	5.6	6.8 5.6
Burkina Faso	8.4	7 8.4	Botswana	5.5	8.1 5.5
Senegal	7.9	7.7 7.9	Seychelles	5.3	5.2 5.3
Benin	7.9	7.6 7.9	Mali	5.2	6 5.2
Cameroon	7.9	5.3 7.9	Namibia	5	5.1 5
Morocco	7.7	7.9 7.7	Chad	5	4.4 5
Uganda	7.4	6.2 7.4	Angola	4.8	5.9 4.8
Rwanda	7.3	9.9 7.3	Mozambique	4.5	5.6 4.5
Egypt	7.3	5.2 7.3	Zimbabwe	4.4	5.2 4.4
Gambia	7.2	5.2 7.2	DR Congo	4.3	5.5 4.3
Comoros	7.2	4.4 7.2	Sierra Leone	3.9	5.4 3.9
Algeria	7.1	5 7.1	South Sudan	3.9	1.7 3.9
Ivory Coast	6.8	7.3 6.8	Mauritania	3.8	5.4 3.8
Tunisia	6.8	5.7 6.8	Liberia	3.8	4.8 3.8
Guinea	6.7	5.6 6.7	Djibouti	3.7	5.7 3.7
South Africa	6.6	8.6 6.6	Somalia	3.7	2.4 3.7
Mauritius	6.6	8.4 6.6	Burundi	3.6	5.4 3.6
Kenya	6.6	7.9 6.6	Cape Verde	3.5	7.3 3.5
Zambia	6.3	7.8 6.3	Malawi	3.5	6.2 3.5
Equatorial Guinea	6.2	5.2 6.2	Central African Republic	3.2	3.1 3.2

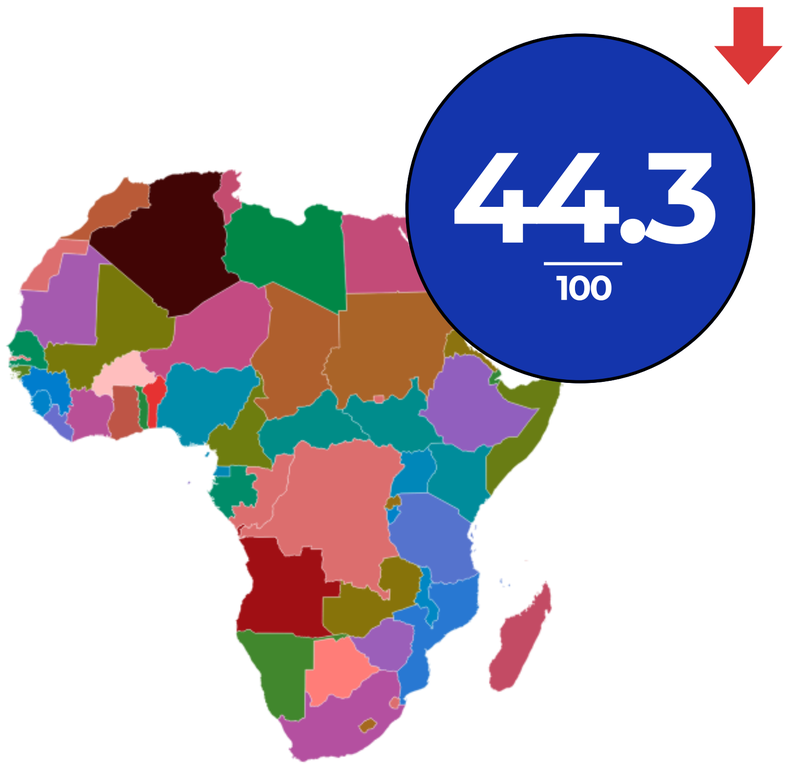
Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Madagascar	3.1	5.9 3.1
Guinea-Bissau	2.7	4 2.7
Lesotho	2.5	6.9 2.5
Sao Tome and Principe	2.4	5.3 2.4
Libya	1.1	2 1.1
Niger	0.1	6.4
Tanzania		5.5
Sudan		3.8
Congo Republic		3.6
Eritrea		1.2

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5.5



Economic Freedom in Africa at a Glance



Economic freedom recorded a notable decline in 2026, with Africa's score falling from 58.9 in 2025 to 44.3, pointing to worsening economic opportunities and conditions across the continent.

Economic freedom refers to the ability of individuals and businesses to make economic decisions without unnecessary government restrictions.

Strong economic freedom generally depends on secure property rights, reasonable taxation, open trade, and an environment where entrepreneurship can flourish. When these conditions are present, people and businesses have greater room to create wealth, invest and generate employment, and the economy can flourish.

Economic freedom in Africa weakened across 2026, falling from 58.9 in 2025 to 44.3 in 2026.

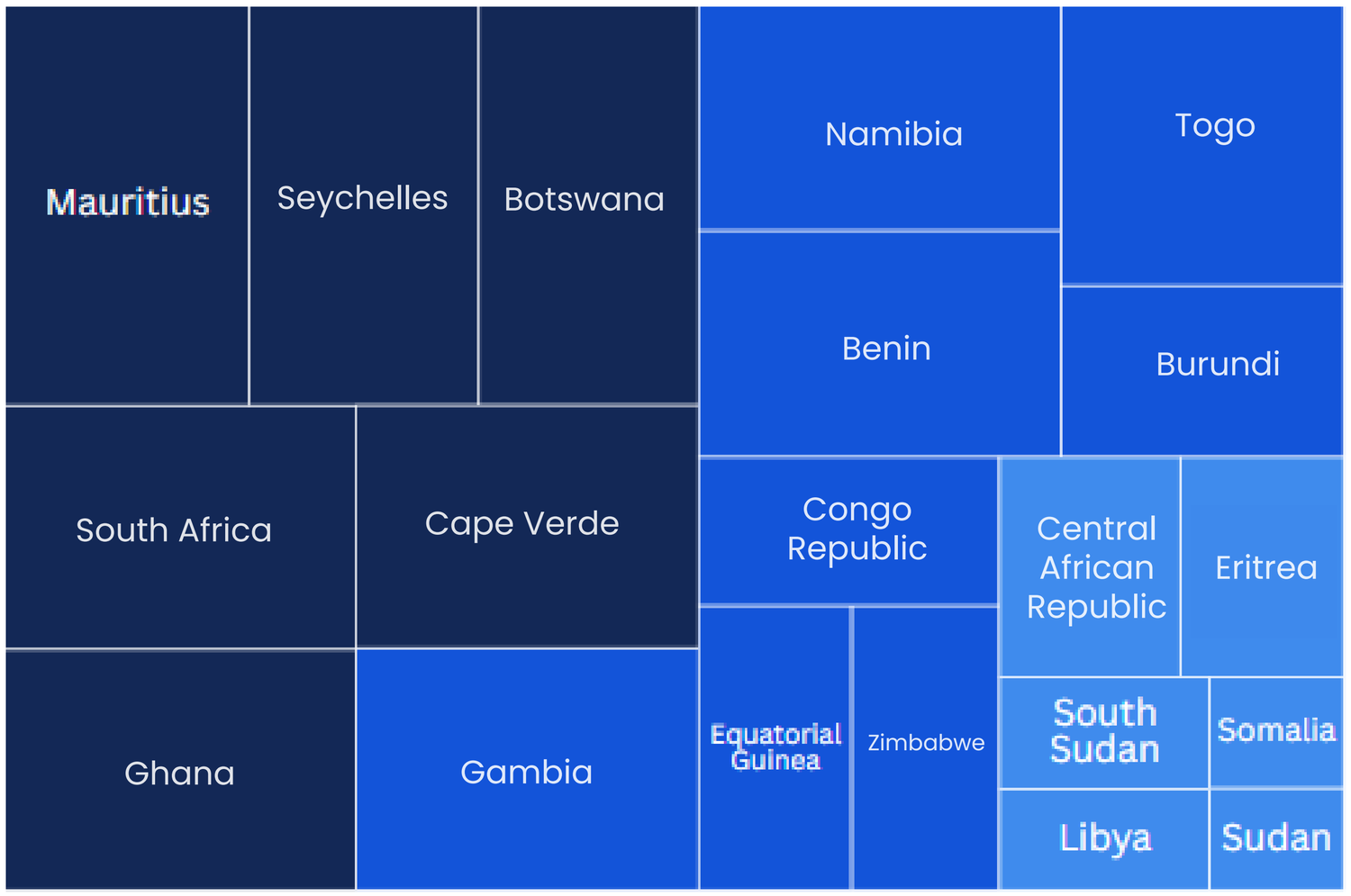
The decline was reflected across several dimensions, including labour freedom and the growth of the digital economy, although the impact was not consistent across the continent. Countries such as Mauritius, Seychelles and South Africa continued to appear among the stronger performers, while several fragile and conflict-affected states recorded very low scores.

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) says Africa needs stronger business regulation, market openness and governance. Its 2026 analysis estimates that making half of the needed reforms could raise output by around 20% over five to ten years.

The World Bank similarly identifies fragmented regulations, trade barriers and weak business systems as constraints on African firms.

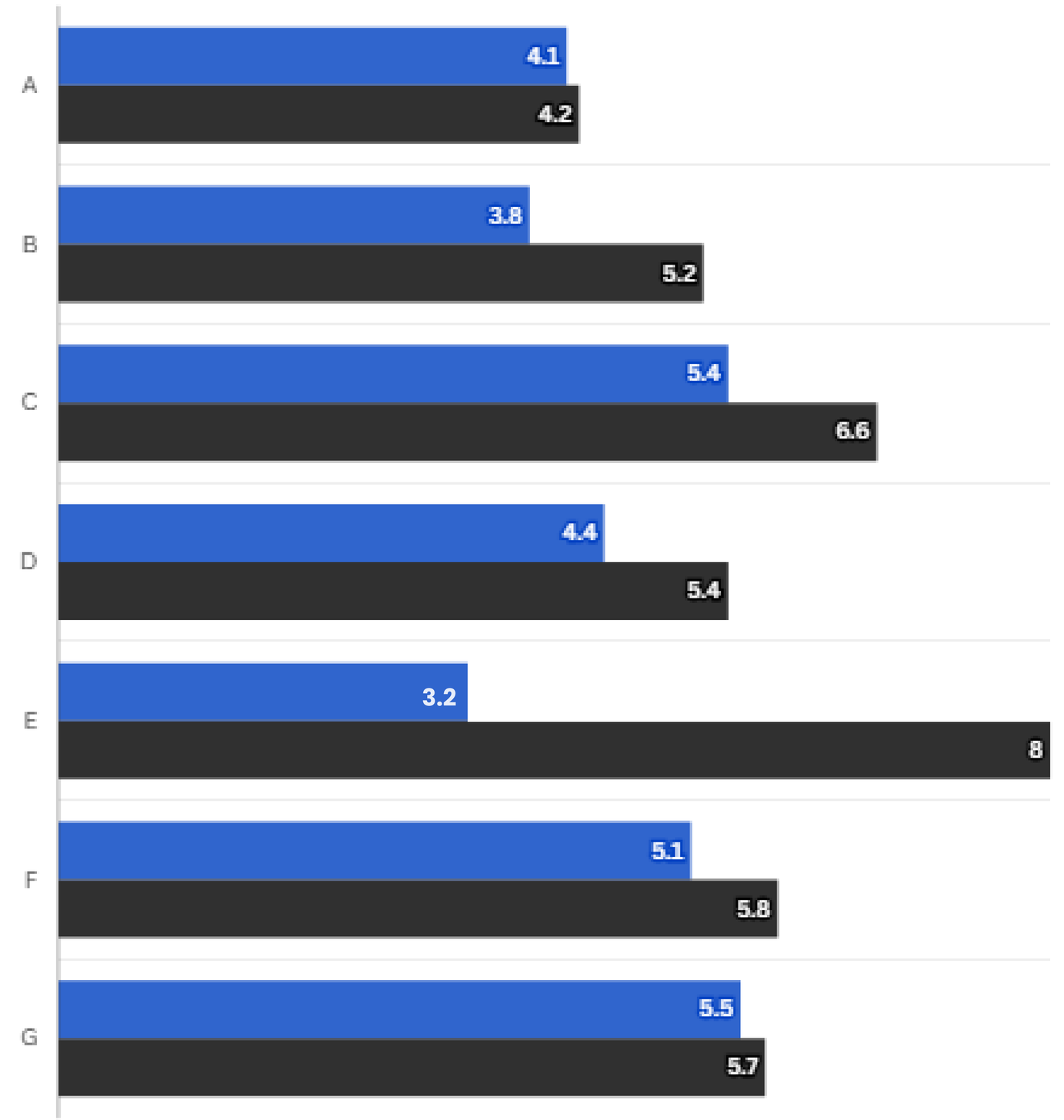
Overall, 2026 marks a setback in Africa's economic freedom. The overall decline highlights continuing challenges across the continent, while differences between countries show the importance of stronger institutions and reforms in creating an environment for sustained economic prosperity.

Figure 16. **Top 10 and Bottom 10 Country Scores, 2026**



The top 10 are Mauritius (8.1), Seychelles (7.3), Botswana (6.6), South Africa (6.3), Ghana (6.3), Cape Verde (5.9), Gambia (5.9), Namibia (5.8), Benin (5.8), and Togo (5.7), while the bottom 10 are Burundi (2.8), Congo Republic (2.8), Equatorial Guinea (2.8), Zimbabwe (2.7), Central African Republic (2.4), Eritrea (2.2), Sudan (2.0), South Sudan (1.9), Libya (1.7), and Somalia (1.2).

Figure 17. **Side by side comparison of 2025 & 2026 Economic Freedom Scores**



A. Property Rights, B. Ease of Starting a Business, C. Trade Freedom, D. Free Movement E. Tax Burden, F. Labour Freedom, G. Digital Economy Growth

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3.0

Prosperity

3.1 Income & Financial Freedom

Figure 18. **Financial Freedom Scores among African countries, 2026**

Income and financial freedom reflects the ability of people to maintain their purchasing power and participate in the economy without excessive monetary instability.

Stable prices are particularly important for households, as high and unpredictable inflation can quickly reduce the value of wages and savings.

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has highlighted this concern, noting that inflation can place a heavier burden on poorer households.

As seen in countries like Somalia, Sudan and South Sudan which continue to face serious monetary and economic pressures, leading to very poor conditions.

Some of the biggest improvements in Africa came from the Central African Republic, Chad and Equatorial Guinea, while Benin, Gabon, Mauritania and Mozambique also made considerable gains.

Seychelles records the highest score, Mauritius retains its strong position, with South Africa and Kenya also improving.

Taken together, these differences highlight the state of the continent's monetary environment.

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Seychelles	9.6	9.3 → 9.6
Cape Verde	9.5	9.1 → 9.5
Mauritius	8.7	8.7 → 8.7
Algeria	8.5	7.8 → 8.5
Botswana	8.3	7.7 → 8.3
Morocco	8.3	6.8 → 8.3
Kenya	8.2	7.2 → 8.2
South Africa	8.2	7.2 → 8.2
Tunisia	8.2	7.6 → 8.2
Rwanda	8.1	7.4 → 8.1
Benin	7.9	5.7 → 7.9
Gabon	7.9	5.9 → 7.9
Tanzania	7.7	6.6 → 7.7
Senegal	7.6	6.1 → 7.6
Uganda	7.6	5.8 → 7.6
Cameroon	7.5	5.8 → 7.5
Mauritania	7.5	5.6 → 7.5
Eswatini	7.2	5.1 → 7.2
Namibia	7.2	5.2 → 7.2
Congo Republic	7.1	4.7 → 7.1
Ghana	7.1	7.4 → 7.1
Lesotho	7	4.9 → 7
Togo	6.9	5.1 → 6.9
Ivory Coast	6.8	5.5 → 6.8
Burkina Faso	6.7	4.8 → 6.7
Guinea	6.7	4.4 → 6.7
Djibouti	6.6	4.8 → 6.6
Sao Tome and Principe	6.5	5.8 → 6.5
Zambia	6.5	5.1 → 6.5
Comoros	6.4	3.9 → 6.4
Eritrea	6.4	3.2 → 6.4
Mali	6.4	3.4 → 6.4
Mozambique	6.3	3.5 → 6.3
Niger	6.2	4.3 → 6.2
Chad	6.1	3.7 → 6.1
Liberia	6.1	3.6 → 6.1
Madagascar	6.1	3.7 → 6.1
Ethiopia	6	5.6 → 6
Nigeria	6	5.3 → 6
Egypt	5.9	5.2 → 5.9
Equatorial Guinea	5.9	3 → 5.9
Gambia	5.8	4.9 → 5.8
Guinea-Bissau	5.7	2.4 → 5.7
Angola	5.6	4.3 → 5.6
Malawi	5.6	4.7 → 5.6
Central African Republic	5.5	1.9 → 5.5
Libya	5.3	1.6 → 5.3
Burundi	5.2	4 → 5.2
DR Congo	5.1	3.4 → 5.1
Sierra Leone	5.1	4 → 5.1
Zimbabwe	2.4	4.9 → 2.4
Sudan	1.5	3.1 → 1.5
Somalia	1.1	2.4
South Sudan	0.1	

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6.5

3.2 Access to Healthcare

Figure 19. **Healthcare Access Scores among African countries, 2026**

Healthcare access is closely tied to quality of life and the ability of people to participate fully in economic and social life.

When medical services are difficult to reach or unaffordable, illness can quickly become a financial burden for households.

The World Health Organization (WHO) continues to identify high out-of-pocket health spending as a major challenge across Africa, with many households still facing financial hardship when accessing essential health care services.

In 2026 access to healthcare is improving. South Africa moved into the strongest position, with Senegal, Nigeria, Liberia, Uganda, Malawi and Egypt making particularly strong advances.

Elsewhere, however, the picture deteriorated sharply. Equatorial Guinea fell from 5.1 to just 0.1, while Burundi and Gabon both declined to 1.3. Chad, the Central African Republic and São Tomé and Príncipe also recorded significant drops.

The gap between these directly affects how households experience economic and social prosperity in their countries. Where medical services become more accessible, improvements in wellbeing follow.

Where access weakens, even rising incomes may provide limited protection against the cost of illness.

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
South Africa	9.6	7.5 → 9.6
Senegal	9	6.3 → 9
Egypt	8.6	7.3 → 8.6
Nigeria	8.3	4.8 → 8.3
Uganda	8.2	6.8 → 8.2
Algeria	7.9	8.2 → 7.9
Mauritius	7.7	7.3 → 7.7
Malawi	7.5	6.4 → 7.5
Liberia	7.5	4.7 → 7.5
Ethiopia	7.3	6.5 → 7.3
Rwanda	7.2	7.3 → 7.2
Kenya	7.1	6.8 → 7.1
Botswana	6.7	7.9 → 6.7
Djibouti	6.6	6.3 → 6.6
Seychelles	6.5	8.7 → 6.5
Cameroon	6.5	5.2 → 6.5
Zambia	6.4	6.5 → 6.4
Sierra Leone	5.9	5.5 → 5.9
Mozambique	5.4	6.3 → 5.4
Ghana	5.1	6.6 → 5.1
Togo	5	5.8 → 5
Morocco	4.9	7.2 → 4.9
Ivory Coast	4.9	6 → 4.9
DR Congo	4.9	4.4 → 4.9
Sudan	4.8	4.3 → 4.8
Lesotho	4.7	5.9 → 4.7
Guinea	4.4	4.9 → 4.4
Cape Verde	4.4	7.7 → 4.4
Mali	4.3	5.7 → 4.3
Zimbabwe	4.2	6.5 → 4.2
Tanzania	4.2	7 → 4.2
Benin	4.2	5.7 → 4.2
Tunisia	4.1	7.3 → 4.1
Niger	3.9	5.5 → 3.9
Gambia	3.8	5.9 → 3.8
Namibia	3.7	6.8 → 3.7
Madagascar	3.7	4.9 → 3.7
Burkina Faso	3.6	6 → 3.6
Comoros	3.4	6.2 → 3.4
Angola	3.3	5.1 → 3.3
Eswatini	3.2	6.8 → 3.2
Eritrea	3.2	5.4 → 3.2
Libya	2.9	6.3 → 2.9
Somalia	2.8	4.4 → 2.8
Mauritania	2.7	5.6 → 2.7
South Sudan	1.8	4.4 → 1.8
Chad	1.5	4.2 → 1.5
Sao Tome and Principe	1.3	6.8 → 1.3
Gabon	1.3	5.9 → 1.3
Central African Republic	1.3	3.1 → 1.3
Burundi	1.3	5.6 → 1.3
Congo Republic	1.2	5.9 → 1.2
Guinea-Bissau	1	4.8 → 1
Equatorial Guinea	0.1	5.1

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4.7

3.3 Education & Literacy

Education remains one of the strongest foundations of long-term prosperity, yet access to it across Africa continues to be shaped by insecurity, poverty and the limited capacity of national education systems.

The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) reports that progress in keeping children in school has slowed sharply in sub-Saharan Africa, with population growth and conflict being amongst the factors disrupting improvements.

UNESCO also reports documented attacks on schools and education across West and Central Africa, including Burkina Faso, Cameroon, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Mali, Niger, and Nigeria.

While there are improvements in certain regions, the education system in others is still plagued with persistent insecurity, weak infrastructure and limited resources placing renewed pressure on access to education.

In these regions schools can become inaccessible, unsafe and years of educational progress can quickly be lost.

What emerges then in Africa is not simply a question of how many children are in school, but whether African education systems can provide stable, safe and meaningful access to learning as populations continue to grow.

Figure 20. **Education & Literacy Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	RANK 2026	Change from last year
Seychelles	9.6	8.7 → 9.6
Equatorial Guinea	9.5	4 → 9.5
Sao Tome and Principe	9.2	6.7 → 9.2
Namibia	9.1	6.4 → 9.1
Libya	9	4.5 → 9
Mauritius	9	9.1 → 9
Botswana	8.7	7.4 → 8.7
Eswatini	8.7	6.2 → 8.7
Zimbabwe	8.7	6.3 → 8.7
Cape Verde	8.5	7.5 → 8.5
South Africa	8.5	6.4 → 8.5
Zambia	8.5	6.6 → 8.5
Gabon	8.2	4.3 → 8.2
Tunisia	7.9	7.6 → 7.9
Algeria	7.8	6.9 → 7.8
Kenya	7.8	7 → 7.8
Congo Republic	7.7	5.3 → 7.7
Lesotho	7.6	6.3 → 7.6
Ghana	7.5	6.6 → 7.5
Tanzania	7.4	6.7 → 7.4
Cameroon	7.3	5 → 7.3
Djibouti	7.3	5.8 → 7.3
Eritrea	7.2	4 → 7.2
Madagascar	7.2	5.3 → 7.2
Uganda	7.2	4.7 → 7.2
Morocco	6.9	6.8 → 6.9
Rwanda	6.8	6.3 → 6.8
Angola	6.6	3.1 → 6.6
Egypt	6.6	7.1 → 6.6
DR Congo	6.4	5.1 → 6.4
Burundi	6.2	4.9 → 6.2
Togo	5.6	6 → 5.6
Malawi	5.4	5.1 → 5.4
Nigeria	5.4	5.4 → 5.4
Mozambique	5.3	5.6 → 5.3
Comoros	5	5.2 → 5
Mauritania	4.4	3.7 → 4.4
Ethiopia	4.2	5.9 → 4.2
Senegal	4.2	5.6 → 4.2
Gambia	4	6.4 → 4
Liberia	3.7	4.5 → 3.7
Ivory Coast	3.6	5.3 → 3.6
Guinea-Bissau	3.4	3.2 → 3.4
Sierra Leone	3.1	6.6 → 3.1
Benin	3	6.3 → 3
Burkina Faso	2.8	5.3 → 2.8
Somalia	2.7	2.7
Central African Republic	2.4	2.1 → 2.4
Mali	2.1	3.5 → 2.1
South Sudan	2	2
Guinea	1.7	4.1 → 1.7
Chad	0.5	3.6
Niger	0.1	3.6
Sudan		3.7

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6.0

3.4 Access to Infrastructure

Infrastructure is the physical foundation of prosperity.

Roads, electricity, water systems, transport networks and reliable connectivity determine how easily people can work, trade, access services and participate in the wider economy.

The African Development Bank (AfDB) has long identified infrastructure deficits as a major obstacle to Africa's transformation, particularly across energy, transport and water. It estimates that Africa faces an annual infrastructure financing gap of about $100 billion, leaving many countries struggling to keep pace with growing demands of population.

And the gap between countries is becoming increasingly visible.

In some parts of Africa, investment in infrastructure is translating into better connectivity and wider access to essential services, while in others, weak networks continue to isolate communities and restrict economic activity.

For ordinary citizens, the consequences are immense: unreliable electricity can disrupt businesses, poor roads can make markets harder to reach, and limited water infrastructure can turn basic services into daily challenges.

Figure 21. **Infrastructure Access Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Mauritius	9.6	8.3 → 9.6
Libya	9.6	6.5 → 9.6
Egypt	9.5	2.5 → 9.5
Tunisia	9.4	6.7 → 9.4
Algeria	9.4	7.2 → 9.4
Seychelles	9.3	7.1 → 9.3
South Africa	8.8	6.5 → 8.8
Cape Verde	8.7	4.3 → 8.7
Botswana	8.4	6.6 → 8.4
Gabon	7.7	4.7 → 7.7
Morocco	7.6	8.8 → 7.6
Ghana	7.3	3.7 → 7.3
Malawi	7.2	2.9 → 7.2
Senegal	6.9	5.9 → 6.9
Rwanda	6.9	4.1 → 6.9
Djibouti	6.9	4.2 → 6.9
Eswatini	6.7	2 → 6.7
Sao Tome and Principe	6.5	3.7 → 6.5
Mali	6.1	3.6 → 6.1
Gambia	6.1	4.9 → 6.1
Lesotho	5.9	3.2 → 5.9
Mauritania	5.8	3.4 → 5.8
Namibia	5.6	5.4 → 5.6
Sudan	5.5	3.5 → 5.5
Comoros	5.4	3.7 → 5.4
Somalia	5.3	2.4 → 5.3
Nigeria	5.3	4.3 → 5.3
Guinea	5.1	5.5 → 5.1
Cameroon	5.1	6 → 5.1
Ivory Coast	5	2.1 → 5
Congo Republic	4.9	2.6 → 4.9
Burundi	4.8	2.9 → 4.8
Liberia	4.7	2.5 → 4.7
Zimbabwe	4.6	3.6 → 4.6
Burkina Faso	4.4	3.3 → 4.4
Equatorial Guinea	4.1	8.5 → 4.1
Angola	3.9	4 → 3.9
Zambia	3.8	4.3 → 3.8
Uganda	3.8	4.2 → 3.8
Tanzania	3.7	4.9 → 3.7
Sierra Leone	3.6	3.1 → 3.6
Kenya	3.6	6.6 → 3.6
Togo	3.5	4.2 → 3.5
Guinea-Bissau	3.3	3 → 3.3
Mozambique	2.7	3.4 → 2.7
Benin	2.7	4.3 → 2.7
Ethiopia	2	5.3 → 2
South Sudan	1.8	1.8
Niger	1.1	2.9
Eritrea	0.9	3
Central African Republic	0.6	
Madagascar	0.4	2.9
DR Congo	0.4	6.1
Chad	0.1	1.9

2025 2026

5.2

3.5 Economic Inequality

Figure 22. **Economic Inequality Scores among African countries, 2026**

Economic inequality is more than the gap between the rich and the poor. It also asks who has access to jobs, education, healthcare, land and other opportunities that allow people to improve their lives and build greater financial security.

A growing economy can still leave large parts of the population behind when these opportunities remain concentrated among a smaller share of society.

The World Bank continues to identify inequality as a major obstacle to inclusive growth in Africa, noting that unequal access to jobs, education, healthcare and productive assets can prevent economic growth from translating into broader improvements in living standards.

Where these opportunities are limited, poverty can persist.

Economic growth may increase national wealth but may not necessarily translate into better living conditions for everyone, because of high inequality

This makes inequality one of the continent's most difficult prosperity challenges; as the wider impact of growth depends heavily on how many people are able to participate in, and benefit from, that growth.

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Egypt	8.8	5.3 → 8.8
Guinea	8.5	4.4 → 8.5
Comoros	8.3	6.4 → 8.3
Ethiopia	8.1	6.2 → 8.1
Seychelles	7.8	2.9 → 7.8
Mauritania	7.8	→ 7.8
Niger	7.6	3.3 → 7.6
Tunisia	7.4	→ 7.4
Guinea-Bissau	7.4	→ 7.4
Nigeria	7.3	3.6 → 7.3
Sudan	7.2	6.9 → 7.2
Benin	7.2	4 → 7.2
Liberia	6.9	3.4 → 6.9
Ivory Coast	6.9	6.5 → 6.9
Sierra Leone	6.8	4.1 → 6.8
Mali	6.8	2.6 → 6.8
Senegal	6.7	2.4 → 6.7
Mauritius	6.5	→ 6.5
Madagascar	6.5	6.9 → 6.5
Chad	6.4	5.3 → 6.4
Burkina Faso	6.4	5.4 → 6.4
Burundi	6.3	4.8 → 6.3
Togo	6.2	4.3 → 6.2
Gabon	6.2	2.8 → 6.2
Malawi	6.1	3.6 → 6.1
Kenya	6.1	3.1 → 6.1
Equatorial Guinea	6.1	2.3 → 6.1
Gambia	6	2.4 → 6
Rwanda	5.8	4.1 → 5.8
Morocco	5.8	2.1 → 5.8
Tanzania	5.5	3.3 → 5.5
Sao Tome and Principe	5.5	2.8 → 5.5
DR Congo	5.2	4.8 → 5.2
Cameroon	5.1	2.9 → 5.1
Cape Verde	5	5.6 → 5
Uganda	4.9	4.1 → 4.9
Central African Republic	4.8	9.6 → 4.8
Ghana	4.7	3.3 → 4.7
South Sudan	4.6	8.2 → 4.6
Djibouti	4.4	4.4 → 4.4
Lesotho	4.3	5.9 → 4.3
Congo Republic	3.3	6.5 → 3.3
Mozambique	3.1	7.9 → 3.1
Zimbabwe	2.9	6.6 → 2.9
Zambia	2.6	8 → 2.6
Angola	2.6	7 → 2.6
South Africa	1.8	3.7 →
Eswatini	1.7	6.5 → 1.7
Botswana	1.6	4.3 →
Namibia	0.5	5.9 →
Somalia		6.2 →
Libya		5.4 →
Eritrea		6.4 →
Algeria		→

2025 2026

5.6

3.6 Peace & Stability

Figure 23. **Peace & Stability Scores among African countries, 2026**

Peace and stability are fundamental to prosperity: where violence and political instability persist, businesses struggle to operate, communities are displaced, and governments find it harder to provide essential services. A stable environment, by contrast, gives households and investors greater confidence to plan for the future.

In the 2026 figures, Mauritius maintained a its score from last year, while Botswana and Ghana improved.

Some of the largest improvements came in countries previously facing severe instability: Sudan rose from 1.1 to 6.2, while Burkina Faso and Ethiopia both moved from 1.9 to 4.3.

Yet serious instability remains concentrated in several states. South Sudan, Tanzania and Somalia remain countries of particular concerns.

The Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP) reports that Sub-Saharan Africa remains one of the world's least peaceful regions, with eight of the 20 least peaceful countries globally. It identifies rising violent conflict, particularly in the Central Sahel, as a major driver.

The data ultimately shows that peace remains one of Africa's clearest dividing lines for prosperity: countries stable and peaceful environments enjoy more prosperity than those trapped in viiolence.

Location	Scores/10	Change from last year
Seychelles	9.6	→ 9.6
Mauritius	9.6	9.6 → 9.6
Botswana	9.2	8.3 → 9.2
Ghana	8.7	8.2 → 8.7
Namibia	8.4	7.8 → 8.4
Togo	8.1	6.4 → 8.1
Gambia	8.1	7.8 → 8.1
Equatorial Guinea	8	7.1 → 8
Sudan	6.2	→ 6.2
Morocco	6.1	7 → 6.1
Congo Republic	6.1	5.9 → 6.1
Zimbabwe	5.9	5.4 → 5.9
Tunisia	5.9	7.1 → 5.9
Zambia	5.8	7.8 → 5.8
Sierra Leone	5.5	8.2 → 5.5
Uganda	5.4	5.2 → 5.4
Madagascar	5.4	7.7 → 5.4
South Africa	5.3	4.9 → 5.3
Angola	5.3	7 → 5.3
Lesotho	5.1	6.1 → 5.1
Eswatini	5.1	6.1 → 5.1
Mozambique	5	5.3 → 5
Senegal	4.9	7.9 → 4.9
Liberia	4.9	7.3 → 4.9
Kenya	4.9	5.5 → 4.9
Gabon	4.9	6.8 → 4.9
Benin	4.9	6 → 4.9
Algeria	4.7	6.6 → 4.7
Ethiopia	4.3	1.9 → 4.3
Burkina Faso	4.3	1.9 → 4.3
Guinea	4	4.7 → 4
Egypt	3.9	5.5 → 3.9
Djibouti	3.9	5.8 → 3.9
Rwanda	3.8	6.9 → 3.8
Niger	3.8	3.3 → 3.8
Ivory Coast	3.8	6.6 → 3.8
Guinea-Bissau	3.6	6.6 → 3.6
Cameroon	3.6	3.2 → 3.6
Mauritania	3.5	5.8 → 3.5
Nigeria	3.2	2.9 → 3.2
Eritrea	3.1	4.2 → 3.1
Chad	3.1	3 → 3.1
Central African Republic	3.1	1.7 → 3.1
Mali	3	1.4 → 3
Burundi	2.8	4.6 → 2.8
Malawi	2.1	7.3 → 2.1
Libya	1.6	3.4 → 1.6
DR Congo	1.6	1.6 →
Somalia	0.9	→
South Sudan	0.1	→
Tanzania	0	6.6 →
Sao Tome and Principe		→
Comoros		→
Cape Verde		→

2025 2026

4.8

3.7 Employment & Entrepreneurship

Figure 24. **Employment Scores among African countries, 2026**

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Burundi	8.9	8.4 8.9
Chad	8.8	6.6 8.8
Tanzania	8.7	6.8 8.7
Benin	8.7	4.4 8.7
Togo	8.6	4.2 8.6
Ivory Coast	8.5	3.8 8.5
Uganda	8.4	6 8.4
Senegal	8.4	3.2 8.4
Mali	8.4	5 8.4
Liberia	8.4	5.7 8.4
Guinea-Bissau	8.4	4.1 8.4
Sierra Leone	8.3	6 8.3
Nigeria	8.3	5.9 8.3
Madagascar	8.3	9 8.3
Ghana	8.3	4.4 8.3
Ethiopia	8.3	5.3 8.3
Cameroon	8.2	4.6 8.2
Burkina Faso	8.2	5.7 8.2
Comoros	8.1	3.4 8.1
Djibouti	8	4.4 8
Malawi	7.8	6.8 7.8
Guinea	7.8	4.7 7.8

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Mauritius	7.7	7.7
Kenya	7.7	4.4 7.7
Zambia	7.6	6.7 7.6
Eritrea	7.6	5.3 7.6
Gambia	7.5	4.4 7.5
Central African Republic	7.5	8.6 7.5
Mozambique	7.4	8.4 7.4
Egypt	7.4	7.4
Equatorial Guinea	7	5.9 7
Zimbabwe	6.8	5.1 6.8
Sao Tome and Principe	6.8	4.9 6.8
Morocco	6.8	6.8
Mauritania	6.5	3.4 6.5
Rwanda	6.2	5 6.2
Algeria	6.2	6.2
Cape Verde	6.1	6.1
Angola	5.6	4.7 5.6
Tunisia	5.3	5.3
Lesotho	5	2.7 5
Libya	4.4	9.6 4.4
Somalia	4.3	5.4 4.3
Namibia	4.2	4.2

Location	Scores/10	Change from Last year
Congo Republic	4.1	6.8 4.1
Gabon	4	9.6 4
Botswana	2.9	2.9
DR Congo	2.6	7.7 2.6
South Africa	1	1
Eswatini	0.5	2.6
Sudan		4.3
South Sudan		
Seychelles		
Niger		7.5

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6.8

Employment and entrepreneurship are closely linked across Africa, but the relationship is not always straightforward.

A strong labor market should provide people with meaningful choices: they should be able to find formal employment, build a business or work independently based on opportunity rather than necessity. Where formal jobs are limited however, self-employment often becomes the main alternative.

The 2026 figures highlight just how different these realities are. Some countries show stronger conditions for employment and entrepreneurship, while others combine weak employment outcomes with very high levels of self-employment. Nigeria, for example, has a particularly high share of people working for themselves.

Self-employment accounts for 96% of workers in Chad, 93% in Sierra Leone, 92% in Madagascar and 89% in Nigeria. Burkina Faso, Burundi, the Central African Republic and Ethiopia also recorded very high levels. By comparison, the share is only 1% in South Africa and 2% in Mauritius.

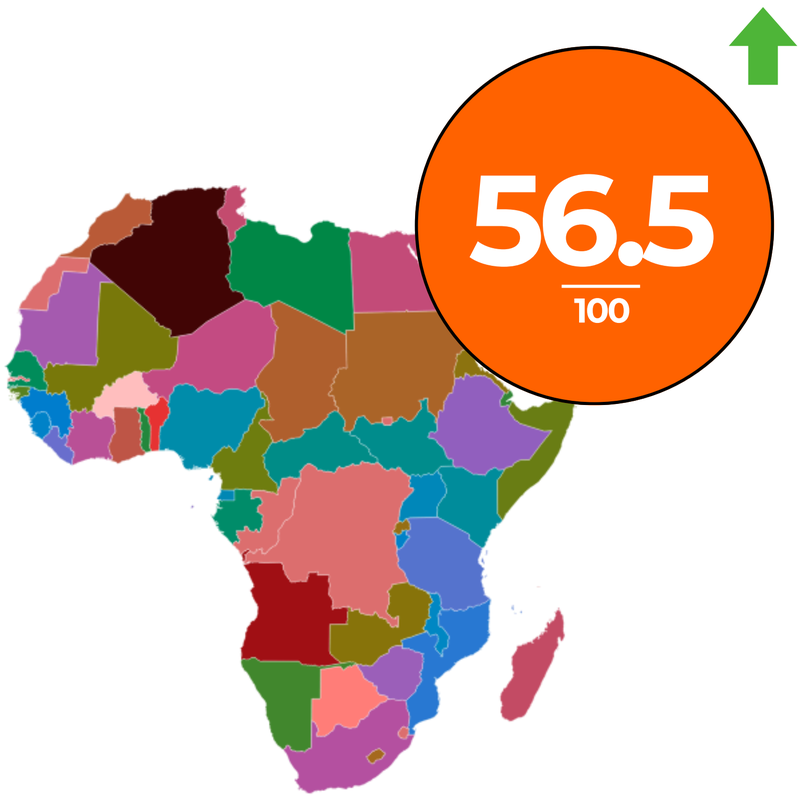
The International Labor Organization (ILO) has repeatedly pointed to the dominance of informal employment across African labor markets. For millions of workers, earning a living outside the formal economy means operating without stable contracts, reliable social protection or easy access to finance.

This creates an important distinction between entrepreneurship as opportunity and entrepreneurship as necessity.

A high level of self-employment can demonstrate initiative and resilience, but it can also reveal how difficult it is for workers to secure formal jobs.

Africa's employment challenge is therefore not simply about reducing unemployment; it is about building a system where people can move from survival-based work into more secure, productive and sustainable economic opportunities.

Prosperity in Africa at a Glance



Africa's overall prosperity score increased from 50.2 in 2025 to 56.5 in 2026. However, insecurity, limited opportunities and weaker access to essential services can still affect people's everyday lives.

Prosperity is ultimately more than economic output. It reflects whether people can translate economic activity into higher incomes, reliable healthcare, quality education, adequate infrastructure, reduced equality, security and meaningful opportunities to work and build businesses.

Progress in income and monetary conditions provided positive movement for Africa on the prosperity index, while improvements in parts of the education, infrastructure and healthcare landscape offered further signs of opportunity.

Yet these gains remain uneven, with persistent challenges in healthcare access, inequality, peace and stability, and employment continuing to affect people's everyday lives.

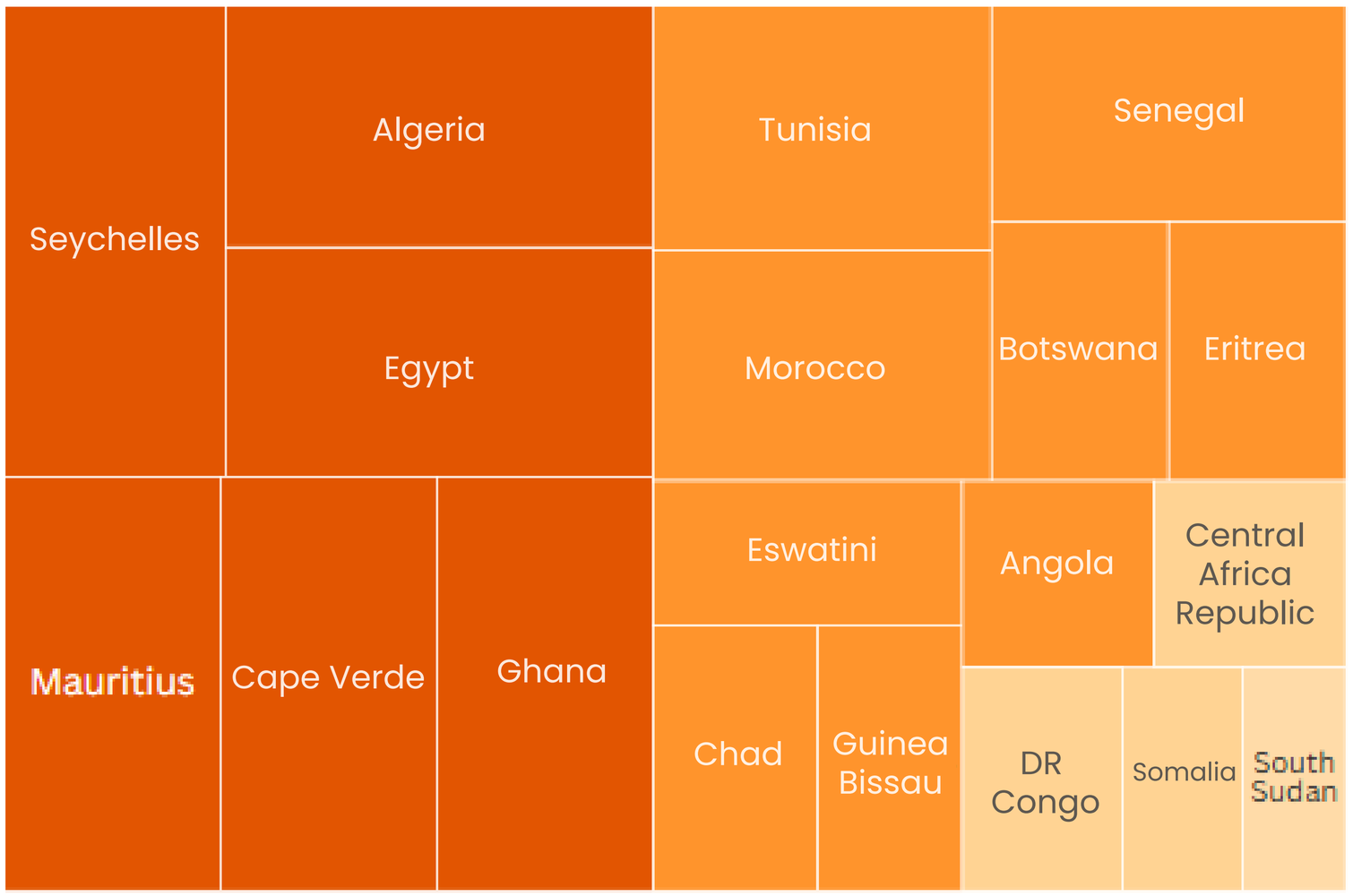
Some economies continue to build stronger foundations for their citizens, while fragile and conflict-affected countries face conditions that make sustained improvements much harder to achieve.

The increase in the overall prosperity score from 50.2 to 56.5 suggests progress in translating economic activity into better living conditions. However, the improvement does not mean that the continent's underlying challenges have been resolved.

Insecurity, unequal access to opportunities and weaknesses in essential services continue to limit how far economic progress can improve people's lives.

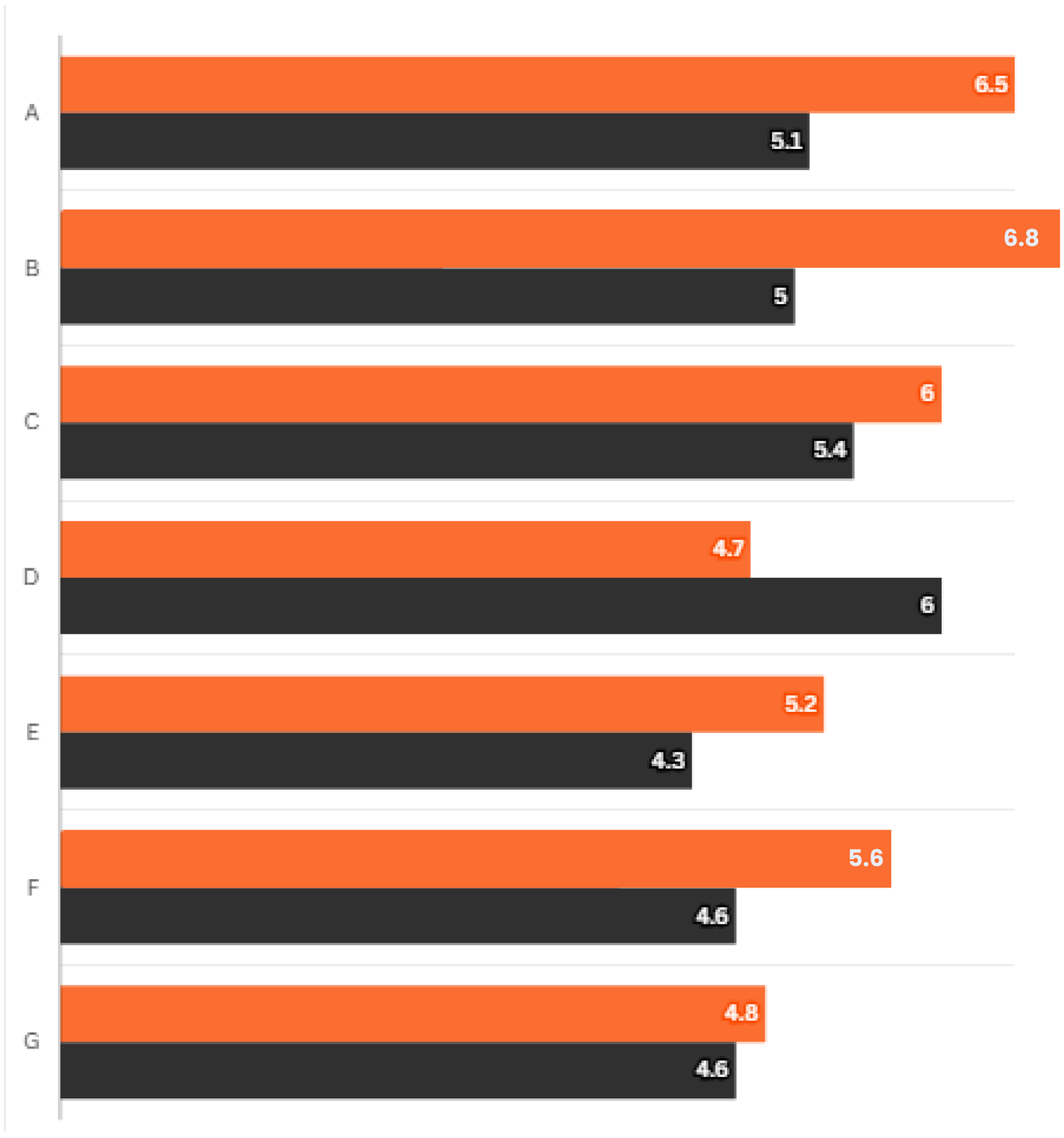
For Africa, the question is increasingly not simply whether economies are growing, but whether that growth is translating into a more secure and better quality of life for the people living within them.

Figure 16. **Top 10 and Bottom 10 Country Scores, 2026**



The top 10 are Seychelles (8.7), Mauritius (8.4), Algeria (7.4), Egypt (7.2), Cape Verde (7.0), Ghana (6.9), Tunisia (6.9), Senegal (6.8), Morocco (6.6), and Botswana (6.5), while the bottom 10 are Eritrea (4.7), Eswatini (4.7), Guinea-Bissau (4.7), Angola (4.7), Chad (3.8), Niger (3.8), DR Congo (3.7), Central African Republic (3.6), Somalia (2.9), and South Sudan (1.7).

Figure 26. **Side by side comparison of 2025 & 2026 Prosperity Scores**



A. Electoral Integrity, B. Employment & Freedom of Entrepreneurship, C. Freedom of Education, D. Access to Healthcarey, E. Access to Infrastructure, F. Inequality in Africa, G. Peace & Stability

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Regional Overview



Africa’s Regional Overview

Mauritius records the highest overall freedom score in the 2026 dataset, at 84.2, followed very closely by Seychelles, then Ghana, Cape Verde, Botswana and South Africa. These countries stand out because they perform relatively well across the three main areas measured in the report: political freedom, economic freedom and prosperity.

Southern Africa shows the strongest overall performance, with South Africa, Botswana, and Namibia all among the continent's highest-ranked countries. West Africa also performs strongly, led by Ghana, Cape Verde, The Gambia and Senegal.

North and Central Africa, however, contain a large concentration of low-scoring countries. East Africa presents the widest contrast, with high-performing countries such as Seychelles alongside much weaker performers including South Sudan and Eritrea.

The differences between regions show that freedom is not determined by one issue alone; strong political institutions, economic opportunity, access to public services, security and respect for individual rights all contribute to how countries perform.

Southern Africa

Southern Africa records the strongest regional performance in the dataset. However, the region is not uniformly strong. Zambia and Zimbabwe score considerably low compared to the rest, showing that countries in the same region can have very different political and economic conditions.

South Africa stands out at the top with an overall score of 70.3. Its performance is relatively unbalanced across the three pillars, scoring 86.5 in political freedom, 63.0 in economic freedom and 61.7 in prosperity.

Freedom House classifies South Africa as Free, while also pointing to challenges including corruption and weaknesses in due process.

Botswana provides another example of institutional strength. The country's 2024 general election resulted in the first peaceful transfer of power from one governing party to another since independence. The change of government demonstrated that political competition and electoral transitions can take place without destabilizing the political system.

Still, the region's strong freedom scores do not mean that its economic challenges have disappeared. The African Development Bank has highlighted continued concerns around infrastructure, economic diversification, and financing.

Overall, Southern Africa's strength comes from a combination of relatively stable institutions, stronger economic systems and higher levels of prosperity. But the differences within the region remain significant, with some countries still struggling to achieve broader gains in freedom and living standards.

Figure 27. **Africa’s Regional Overview**

East Africa	2025	2026
Seychelles	76.6	84.1 ↑
Mauritius	80	84.2 ↑
Malawi	62.5	60.0 ↘
Burundi	37.2	34.2 ↘
Kenya	62.3	62.5 ↑
Tanzania	53.6	53.8 ↑
Madagascar	51	51 ↘
Uganda	50.8	48.7 ↘
Mozambique	47.5	45.5 ↘
Rwanda	50.7	47.7 ↘
Comoros	47.3	51.1 ↑
Djibouti	46.7	45.7 ↘
Ethiopia	45.9	43.8 ↘
Eritrea	30.6	25.3 ↓
Somalia	25.7	26.3 ↗
South Sudan	19.3	19.6 ↗

North Africa	2025	2026
Tunisia	67.7	59.9 ↘
Algeria	56.9	52.7 ↘
Morocco	61.7	61.8 ↑
Egypt	50.6	46.2 ↘
Sudan	36.4	33.4 ↘
Libya	34	33.6 ↘

South Africa	2025	2026
Eswatini	49	40.0 ↓
Namibia	69.4	65.8 ↘
Lesotho	63	61.7 ↘
Botswana	75.3	71.2 ↘
South Africa	74.3	70.3 ↘
Zambia	56.6	58.5 ↑
Zimbabwe	45.1	36.7 ↘

Western Africa	2025	2026
Cape Verde	79.8	73.1 ↘
Ghana	68.8	73.4 ↑
Senegal	64.4	66.0 ↘
Gambia	62.6	67.4 ↑
Benin	60.4	60.2 ↘
Ivory Coast	59.4	57.3 ↘
Liberia	56.6	56.9 ↑
Sierra Leone	55.8	56.4 ↑
Togo	54.8	55.4 ↑
Mauritania	55.3	45.2 ↘
Nigeria	54.4	59.6 ↑
Burkina Faso	53.6	47.7 ↘
Niger	51.3	43.3 ↘
Guinea-Bissau	52.3	43.3 ↓
Guinea	46.1	45.4 ↘
Mali	49	47.2 ↘

Central Africa	2025	2026
Sao Tome and Principe	69.3	64.2 ↘
Angola	49	50.2 ↑
Gabon	53.6	59.2 ↑
Cameroon	40.8	45.0 ↗
Congo Republic	41.2	44.8 ↗
Chad	39.7	27.9 ↓
Equatorial Guinea	35.7	33.9 ↘
DR Congo	37.8	39.2 ↗
Central African Republic	31.2	33.5 ↗

The regional picture reveals significant differences across Africa, with Southern Africa recording some of the continent's highest scores. Botswana leads the region at 71.2, followed by South Africa (70.3) and Namibia (65.8), while Lesotho (61.7) also performs relatively strongly. East Africa presents a wide range of outcomes, with Mauritius (84.2) and Seychelles (84.1) recording the highest scores, while South Sudan (19.6), Eritrea (25.3) and Somalia (26.3) remain at the bottom. West Africa shows considerable variation, led by Ghana (73.4), Cape Verde (73.1) and Senegal (66.0), while Niger (43.3), Guinea-Bissau (43.3) and Guinea (45.4) record lower scores. North Africa also presents mixed results, with Morocco (61.8) and Tunisia (59.9) performing relatively strongly, compared with Sudan (33.4) and Libya (33.6). Central Africa records varied outcomes, with São Tomé and Príncipe (63.6) and Gabon (57.6) standing out, while Chad (32.5), the Central African Republic (34.9) and Equatorial Guinea (35.4) record some of the region's lowest scores.

Western Africa

The story of West Africa is not simply one of political decline. Some of its economies continue to show resilience, with growth supported by agriculture, investment and infrastructure.

On that side are regions where economic institutions remain relatively strong. Their stronger performance is a reflection of more established democratic systems and greater room for political participation. Ghana offers one of the clearest examples of what this difference looks like on the ground. Its political system has remained competitive, with regular peaceful elections, change in government, and a strong tradition of public participation. That political stability has also been matched by relatively strong economic conditions. While Ghana still faces challenges such as inequality, unemployment and pressure on public services, its institutions give citizens and businesses more room to organize, speak out and pursue opportunities than in many neighboring countries.

As we begin to move further down the regions into the Sahel however, the picture changes. With numerous coups, insecurity and military rule, putting pressure on democratic freedom in these states, the freedom scores of these countries are low.

Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger have experienced coups and growing insecurity, while military governments have tightened their hold on power.

Freedom House's 2026 assessment points to the continued consolidation of military rule in these countries and a wider decline in political freedoms.

Eastern Africa

East Africa contains some of the widest differences in freedom across the continent.

Seychelles stands at the top of the region, with strong performance across all three areas measured by the report. Mauritius follows closely.

Kenya also has a relatively strong political environment, with space for political participation and public debate, but its economic freedom and prosperity scores are much more on the moderate side. Tanzania and Uganda sit further down the regional ranking, while Rwanda presents a very different model altogether and is particularly revealing; Its prosperity score is considerably stronger than its political freedom score, showing that improvements in economic and social conditions do not always come with greater political freedom. The country has made progress in areas such as development and public services, while political opposition and civic space remain more restricted.

As we move further down however, the picture becomes much more difficult. South Sudan, Eritrea and Somalia remain among the region's weakest performers. Conflict, insecurity, political restrictions and fragile institutions continue to limit both individual freedom and economic opportunity. South Sudan is especially affected, with very low scores across political freedom, economic freedom and prosperity.

Northern Africa

Morocco sits at the top of the regional ranking, followed by Tunisia and Algeria.

The country has built relatively strong economic institutions and developed a growing economy; Tunisia shows a similar pattern, with its Economic freedom score ahead of its prosperity scores and political freedom score.
Egypt shows an even wider margin. Despite recording a prosperity score of 72.4 and an economic freedom score of 44.3, its political freedom score is just 21.0.

These differences point to something important; a country can make economic and social progress without opening the same space for political participation.
The situation is worser in states like Sudan and Libya which have been deeply entrenched in conflict, causing political instability and weakened state institutions. The region's divide shows why looking at only one measure for freedom can be misleading. Economic strength can exist alongside political restrictions, with conflict weakening all three areas at once.

According to the African Development Bank, Northern Affrica is expected to grow by around 4.0% in 2026, although geopolitical tensions and global trade pressures remain important risks.

Central Africa:

Central Africa has fewer countries performing strongly across all three pillars. São Tomé and Príncipe stands clearly ahead of the rest of the region, with Angola and Gabon following behind.

Indicator scores for Angola are spread fairly evenly across the three areas. There is no single area pulling the country's overall performance sharply downward. Suggesting that political, economic and prosperity outcomes have developed at roughly similar levels.

São Tomé and Príncipe is quite the opposite situation as Its political freedom score is particularly strong, but this has not been matched by similar levels of economic freedom or prosperity.

Insecurity, limited economic opportunity and weak institutions, bring Chad's prosperity score to 37.9, while the Central African Republic comes out with a weak economic score of 24.3 with prosperity score of 36.0.

This is what makes progress in Central Africa particularly challenging: problems in one area often appear alongside problems in another, leaving fewer areas of strength to offset them. Unlike regions where strong political institutions or stronger economies can lift a country's overall position, several Central African countries face weaknesses across multiple parts of the freedom and prosperity picture at the same time.

Cross-Country Comparisons

The most revealing feature of the dataset is that there is no single formula for freedom. Countries achieve high overall scores through different combinations of political, economic and social strengths.

Ghana vs Nigeria

The comparison between Ghana and Nigeria is particularly useful because both are major West African countries with large populations and significant regional influence.

Ghana scores 73.4 overall, compared with Nigeria's 59.6.

A major difference is their political freedom scores: Ghana records 88.3, while Nigeria records 59.3. This does not mean political freedom alone causes higher prosperity, but the relationship between all three is important: stronger institutions can improve accountability, policy stability and confidence in the rules governing economic activity.

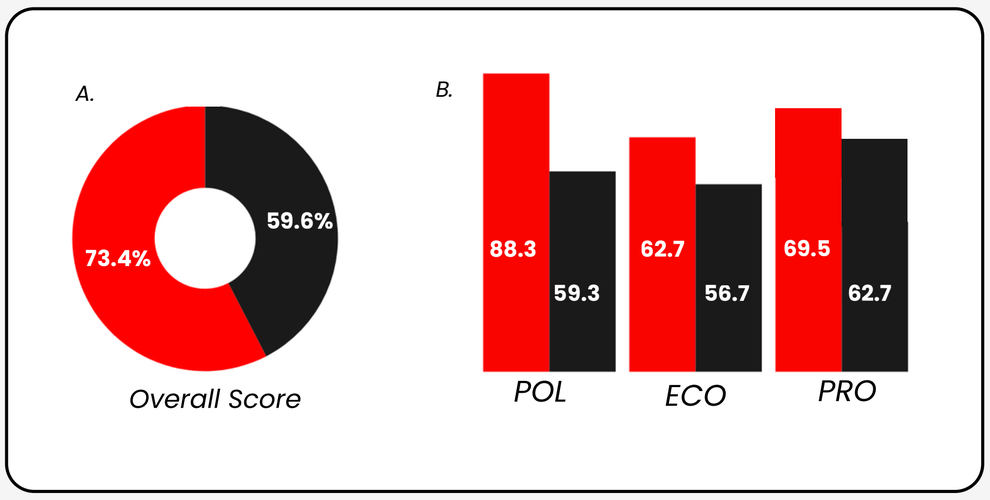


Figure 28. **Ghana V. Nigeria**

Ghana and Nigeria are both major West African countries, but Ghana records stronger results across all three areas. POL (Political Freedom) stands at 88.3 for Ghana, compared with 59.3 for Nigeria, while ECO (Economic Freedom) is 62.7 versus 56.7. PRO (Prosperity) also favors Ghana at 69.5, compared with Nigeria's 62.7. Overall, Ghana scores 73.4, while Nigeria scores 59.6.

Seychelles vs South Africa

Seychelles and South Africa show that a country can reach a high overall position through different strengths. Seychelles leads South Africa, politically, economically and in prosperity. These scores help explain why Seychelles ranks highest overall [91.6 vs 86.5 political freedom; 73.3 vs 63.0 economic freedom; 87.3 vs 61.7 prosperity].

Mauritius vs Rwanda

Mauritius and Rwanda offer perhaps the clearest reminder that prosperity and political freedom do not always progress together. Rwanda has achieved relatively strong economic and social outcomes despite much weaker political freedom, while Mauritius performs strongly across all three pillars [87.6 vs 27.6 political freedom; 84.1 vs 64.1 prosperity].

Botswana vs Zimbabwe

Botswana and Zimbabwe show how institutions can shape a country's wider outcomes. Botswana's greater political stability is matched by stronger economic conditions and prosperity, while Zimbabwe's weaker institutions are reflected across all three areas [71.2 vs 36.7 overall].

The Way Forward: Five Regional Priorities

Southern Africa has a strong foundation to build on. The next step is to turn institutional stability into broader economic opportunity and better living conditions. Countries such as South Africa, Botswana, Namibia and Mauritius can focus on reducing unemployment, improving infrastructure, supporting private enterprise and making growth more inclusive. For countries performing less strongly, the priority is to strengthen institutions and create a more predictable environment for investment and jobs. The region shows that strong political systems can provide a foundation for prosperity, but that foundation still needs to reach more people.

West Africa needs to protect the democratic gains already made while addressing the insecurity and economic pressures affecting parts of the region. Ghana, Cabo Verde and Senegal show what relatively stable institutions can produce, while the experience of the Sahel shows how quickly political instability can reverse progress. A way forward will require stronger democratic institutions, credible elections, accountable governments and greater investment in jobs and basic services. Tackling insecurity is equally important, because lasting economic development becomes difficult when citizens and businesses cannot operate safely.

East Africa faces a different challenge: closing an unusually wide gap between countries. The region has examples of strong political freedom and prosperity alongside countries facing conflict, repression and extreme institutional weakness. The priority should be to strengthen basic institutions, expand civic freedoms and improve access to education, healthcare, infrastructure and economic opportunity. The next challenge is ensuring that development is accompanied by greater space for citizens to participate and hold power accountable.

North Africa needs to narrow the distance between economic development and political freedom. Several countries have built stronger economic and social systems without achieving the same level of political openness. The way forward is therefore not simply faster growth, but greater accountability, stronger civic institutions, wider political participation and more room for independent media and civil society. At the same time, countries affected by conflict and instability will need to restore basic security and functioning institutions before wider economic gains can take hold.

Central Africa faces the most difficult starting point. For several countries, political weakness, limited economic opportunity and low prosperity appear together, making it harder to solve one problem in isolation. The way forward must therefore begin with the basics: stronger public institutions, greater political stability, improved infrastructure, better access to essential services and a business environment capable of creating jobs. Countries such as São Tomé and Príncipe and Gabon show that stronger performance is possible within the region. The broader challenge is turning these pockets of progress into a wider regional trend.

Africa does not need one single model of progress. Each region has different obstacles, and its priorities must reflect them. The countries that make the greatest gains will be those that treat political rights, economic opportunity, and prosperity as connected parts of the same development process.



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Special Themes Edition







Visa-Free Africa and Mobility; How Free Is Movement on the Continent?



This chart highlights the breakdown of entry rules across all cross-border travel routes on the continent. The data shows a positive shift toward easier access, with a combined 53% of travel paths no longer requiring a strict prior visa. This progress is driven by a steady climb in Visas on Arrival (25%) and Visa-Free travel (28%), which has successfully pushed pre-departure visa restrictions down to 47% continent-wide.

Ease of travel helps economies grow. It boosts tourism, business, and trade between countries. A World Bank report shows that improving travel services could increase trade across Africa by up to 64% by 2035. Today, strict visa rules still stop many businesses and workers from growing.

The travel rules are changing, but progress remains slow. Recently, the number of ports across Africa offering visa-free entry increased to 814. However, ports that still require travellers to obtain a regular visa also increased to 1,463.

Still, things are moving forward. Togo recently opened its borders to all African travelers for visa-free entry. This makes it the fifth country to do so, joining Kenya, The Gambia, Benin, and Rwanda. Soon, Central Africa will open up too, as Chad and the Republic of the Congo plan to drop all visa rules for Africans on January 1, 2027.

Right now, traveling smoothly across the whole continent is not yet normal. The next big step is to connect these separate country rules so that all Africans can travel, trade, and study anywhere with fewer problems.

Regional differences across the continent remain significant. Travel rules in Central Africa are considerably more restrictive than those in East Africa, highlighting a major gap in mobility between the two regions.

However, meaningful progress is underway even without a unified, continent-wide system. Today, 33 African nations allow visa-free entry to citizens from at least ten other countries on the continent, courtesy of reginal economic blocs.

Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS)

ECOWAS has the strongest regional free-travel system in Africa. Its members allow 100% visa-free travel, meaning citizens can visit other ECOWAS countries without any visa paperwork. This system started with a special agreement in 1979 and uses a shared ECOWAS passport.
However, the group faced a major shift when Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger left the alliance, reducing the bloc to 12 countries. Even with this change, visa-free travel remains fully active among the remaining 12 nations.

To make regional travel and business even easier, ECOWAS leaders are moving ahead with plans to launch a single regional currency, called the ECO, by 2027.

While passport-free travel is still a core rule, security checks have become stricter along the borders shared with the countries that left the group.

East African Community (EAC)

EAC is one of the easiest regions to travel through in Africa. It ranks second out of the eight regional groups for open borders. Within this group, more than half of the countries allow each other's citizens to enter completely visa-free.

Rwanda and Kenya are the most welcoming countries in the region. In fact, Kenya recently removed its online travel authorization (eTA) fees for most African citizens to make travel even faster. Somalia also signed a new deal to allow easier entry for Tanzanian citizens. However, countries like South Sudan, and Somalia still have strict travel rules for most other visitors. For example, Somalia requires most travelers to apply for an online e-Visa before they fly.

Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA)

COMESA is one of the biggest regional groups on the continent, with 21 member countries. It ranks fourth out of the eight regional groups for open borders.

Kenya and Eritrea made the biggest travel improvements in the region. Kenya became much more welcoming by removing its online travel authorization (eTA) requirements for most African citizens.

However, traveling within COMESA can still be difficult. Only 17% of countries in this group share mutual visa-free travel rules, which is the lowest rate of any regional group on the continent. In addition, nearly half of the travel routes in COMESA have conflicting rules depending entirely on which country a traveler is coming from.

To fix these travel barriers, COMESA leaders met to fast-track changes. They are working to get more member states to fully adopt a 90-day visa-free rule to make trading and visiting each other much easier.

Intergovernmental Authority on Development (IGAD)

IGAD has made great progress in opening its borders. Kenya has been the main country driving this change. At the same time.

Even with these positive changes, traveling within this region can still be tough. Only 21% of travel routes in IGAD countries allow citizens to visit each other completely visa-free. To fix this, the region created a "Free Movement Protocol" back in 2021 to allow easier border crossings. So far, five member countries have signed it, but it cannot start until governments formally pass it into law.

Uganda is leading the way to get this agreement working. In July 2026, the Ugandan government approved a plan to run between August 2026 and March 2027. This plan will help fast-track the official legal approval needed to open its borders to the rest of the region.

Southern African Development Community (SADC)

SADC ranks fifth out of the eight regional groups for open borders. Its overall score dropped slightly because Seychelles started requiring all visitors to fill out an online travel authorization before flying.

There were good changes however, as Mozambique became the most open country in the region after dropping visa rules for many travelers, and Zambia moved into Africa's top 20 most open nations.

To fix these differences in the region, SADC leaders signed a major agreement in August 2026 to create a single regional visa called the SADC UNIVISA. A pilot program is currently being set up between Angola, Mozambique, Namibia, South Africa, and Zimbabwe so travelers can move between these five countries much more easily

Community of Sahel-Saharan States (CEN-SAD)

CEN-SAD's overall visa openness score is right in the middle compared to other regions on the continent. Because it has so many countries, travel rules vary heavily from place to place. The Gambia, Benin, and Ghana are very welcoming, while Egypt, Libya, and Sudan keep their borders much more restricted.

Recently, the region's overall travel score dropped because more than 180 travel routes added new visa requirements. Only 34% of these countries allow each other's citizens to visit completely visa-free without any paperwork. Meanwhile, the number of routes that require a visa before you fly rose from 18% to 25%.

To help open up the region, Togo recently dropped all visa requirements for African travelers, and Chad announced it will do the same starting January 1, 2027. These changes are expected to make travel across this part of Africa much easier soon.

Economic Community of Central African States (ECCAS)

ECCAS remains one of Africa's least open regions, with an AVOI score of 0.327 in 2025. Most member states remain among the lower-ranked countries, although Burundi and Rwanda perform better.

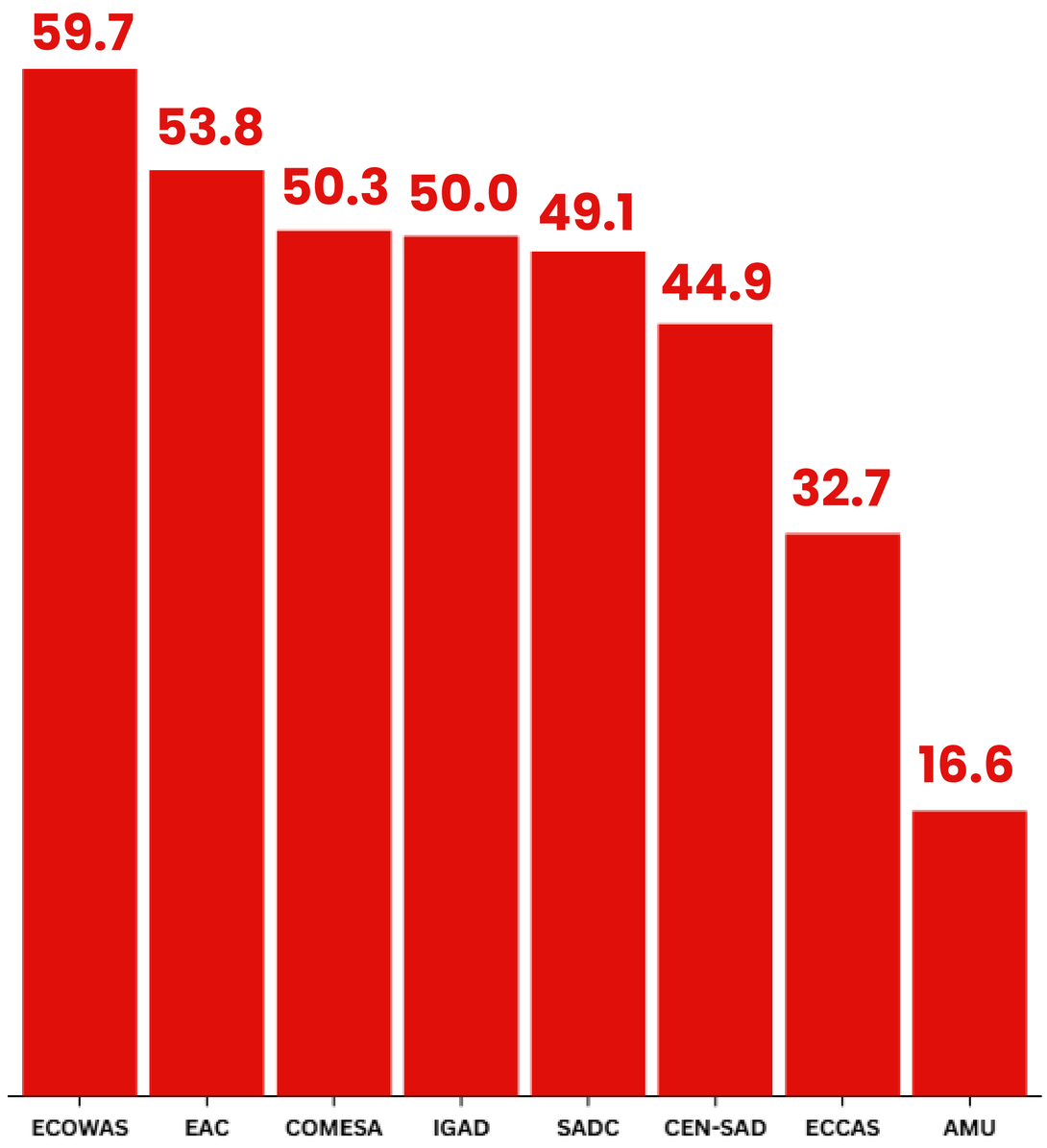
The region did make a little progress recently. The number of countries offering mutual visa-free travel to each other rose from 33% to 38%. This improvement happened because Equatorial Guinea opened its borders to a few more neighboring countries. However, nations like Angola, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and São Tomé and Príncipe still require most visitors to get a strict visa before they travel.

Arab Maghreb Union (AMU)

The Arab Maghreb Union (AMU) includes Algeria, Libya, Mauritania, Morocco, and Tunisia. It is the hardest regional group to travel through in Africa. Its travel openness score has dropped to its lowest point since tracking began in 2016.

Moving between these neighboring countries is highly restricted. Previously, 70% of travel routes within the group were visa-free, but that has now dropped to 60%. While Algeria and Tunisia are still fairly welcoming to other AMU citizens, new rules in Algeria, Morocco, and Mauritania have made traveling much tougher. Libya remains the most strict, requiring a traditional visa from almost every African country.

Traveling through this region has become even more complicated because Morocco started requiring a mandatory online travel authorization (ETA) for visitors from neighboring countries. Because the AMU is struggling to work together, Algeria, Tunisia, and Libya have started meeting on their own to create a separate group to try and make border security and travel a bit easier between the three nations.



This chart illustrates the massive visa-openness gap between Africa's regional blocs. ECOWAS (59.7) and the EAC (53.8) lead the continent as the most integrated and open regions. Conversely, Central Africa's ECCAS (32.7) and North Africa's AMU (16.6) remain heavily restrictive. This data reveals that true continental mobility is highly unequal, split between open eastern/western blocs and insulated central/northern blocs.

Digital Freedom in Africa: A Continent Under Increasing Digital Pressure

Africa’s digital economy is growing fast, but online freedom is facing heavy pressure. A report by the GSMA shows that mobile tech added $240 billion to Africa's economy, supported 13 million jobs, and made up 7.8% of its total GDP. Even with this growth, about 63% of Africans who live near mobile networks still do not use mobile internet because smartphones and data cost too much.

The clearest sign of shrinking digital freedom is the rise in internet shutdowns. Teams at Access Now recorded 30 shutdowns across 15 African countries, which is up from 21 shutdowns previously. Most blackouts happened during political protests, instability, or elections. Tanzania had the most disruptions, cutting the internet eight times.

Governments are also blocking apps, making strict cybercrime laws, and tracking people online. According to Freedom House, South Africa is the only country ranked Free with a score of 73/100. Ghana (64), Nigeria (59), and Uganda (52) are ranked Partly Free. Rwanda remains highly restricted, while Ethiopia is ranked Not Free with a low score of 30.

These internet blackouts hurt the economy by blocking mobile payments, online shopping, and remote work. The World Bank warns that a nationwide shutdown in Kenya can cost $1.2 million in GDP for every two hours the internet is down.

To help more people get online safely and cheaply, the GSMA launched a new partnership to build and sell special $40 4G smartphones in countries like Nigeria, Uganda, and Rwanda. Keeping the internet reliable, open, and cheap is now critical for Africa's future growth.

Africa is becoming increasingly dependent on digital connectivity for economic growth and civic participation, as such, protecting reliable and open internet access is increasingly important.



Countries with internet shutdowns in Africa in 2025: Angola, Cameroon, Central African Republic, Chad, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Ethiopia, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Kenya, Nigeria, South Sudan, Tanzania, Togo, and Uganda. A total of 15 countries (27.8%) experienced shutdowns, while 39 countries (72.2%) did not. (Source: Access Now, Internet Shutdowns in Africa, 2025, published 2026).



Civic Movements and Youth Participation

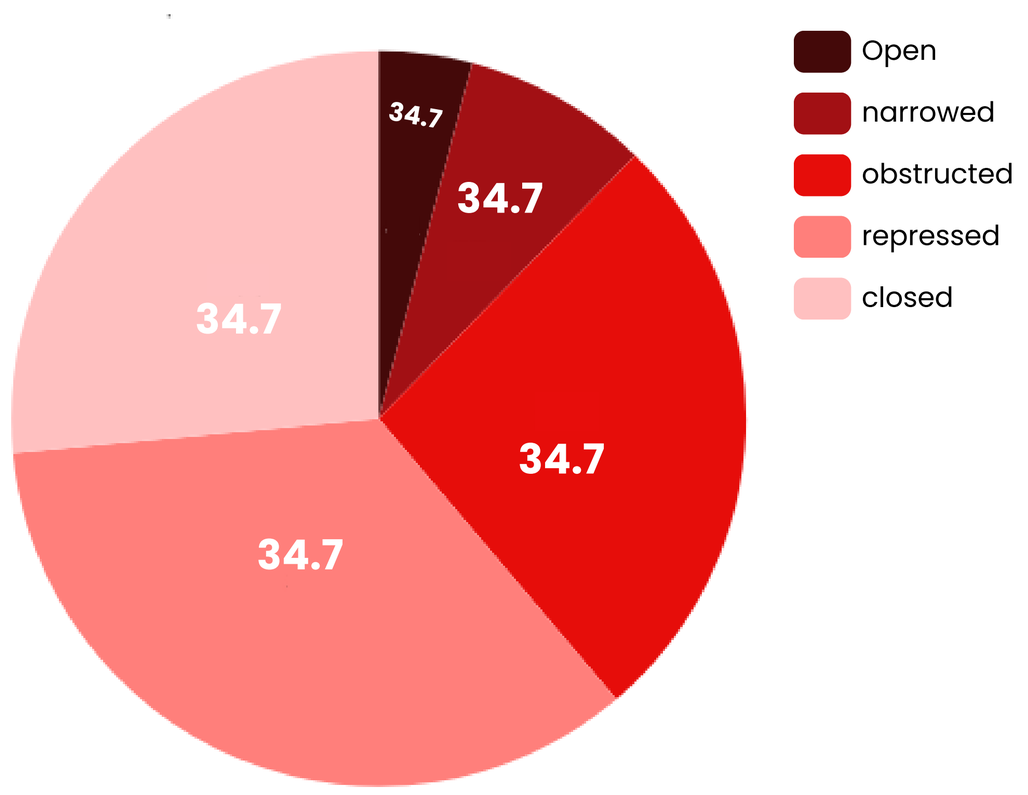
Across Africa, young people and civil society groups are becoming powerful forces for political change. This is especially true where governments are weak or public trust is low. The massive size of this challenge is clear from the CIVICUS Monitor. Their data shows that 44 out of 50 countries in Sub-Saharan Africa have restricted, repressed, or fully closed civic spaces. Today, more than 80% of the population in this region lives under these strict rules.

Despite these barriers, youth-led groups continue to fight corruption, high living costs, police abuse, and bad governance. Kenya is one of the clearest examples. Huge, youth-led protests in 2024 forced the government to drop a controversial tax bill, but the state's response was brutal, causing 60 deaths and 1,200 arrests. When rallies returned, over 65 people were killed and 1,500 were detained. In major 2026 updates, a report by Amnesty International Kenya showed that protests spiked by 29% in early 2026, leading to over 1,000 fresh arrests and documented cases of police torture during new economic rallies.

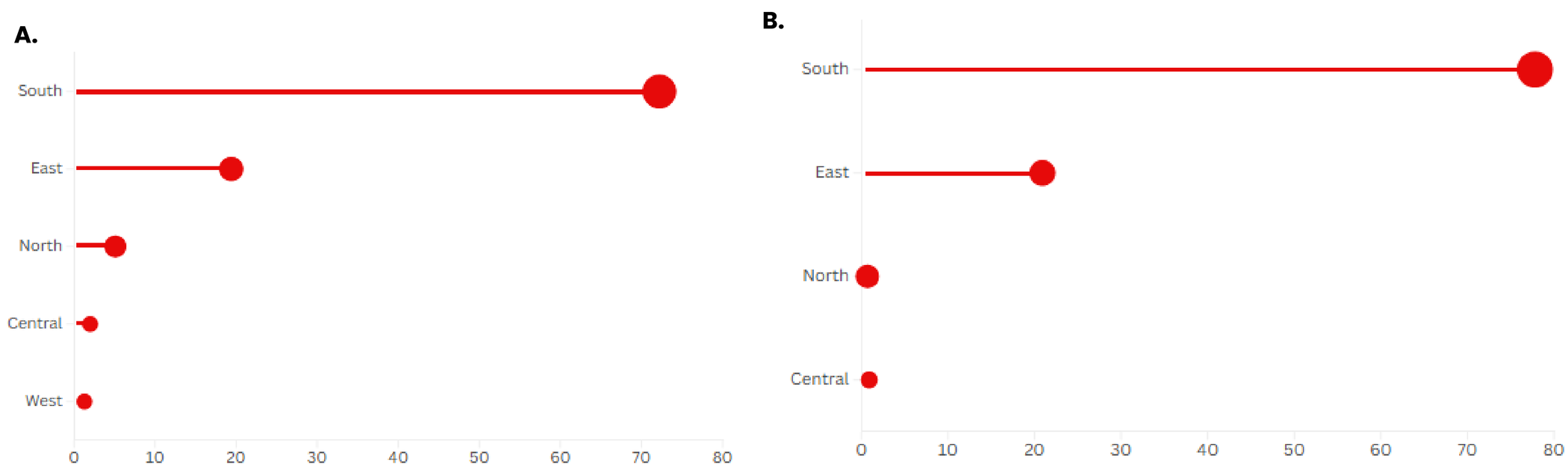
Uganda shows a similar pattern of youth activism facing heavy pressure. Young people have marched against government corruption, political abuse, and local environmental dangers. However, authorities have responded by blocking demonstrations and locking up leaders. Human Rights Watch documented multiple arrests of young activists who spoke out against the major East African Crude Oil Pipeline.

The overall data clearly shows this growing tension. Police locked up protestors in at least 19 African countries, and security forces used excessive, violent force in at least 20 nations. At the same time, youth movements are expanding past traditional politics. They are using social media for digital activism, starting environmental campaigns, fighting corruption, and organizing local communities.

Young people are increasingly willing to challenge power and demand honest leaders. However, turning these street protests into lasting, legal government reform remains heavily limited by police crackdowns, weak courts, and restricted political space.



89.8% of monitored African countries (44 out of 49) fall into the Obstructed, Repressed, or Closed categories. This means the vast majority of people on the continent live in environments with heavily restricted civic freedoms.



A. *Southern Africa accounted for 72.2% of documented arrests and detentions, with 5,715 arrests, driven heavily by mass protest crackdowns. East Africa followed with 19.4%, representing 1,539 arrests, while North Africa recorded 5.1%, or 400 arrests. Central Africa accounted for 2.0%, with 158 arrests, and West Africa recorded the lowest share at 1.3%, with 104 arrests.* ***B.*** *Southern Africa accounted for 77.8% of documented deaths, with 330 deaths, while East Africa recorded 20.5%, with 87 deaths. Central Africa accounted for 0.9%, with 4 deaths, North Africa recorded 0.7%, with 3 deaths, There was no record for West Africa.*

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Policy Recommendation



Policy Recommendation

The findings of the Freedom in Africa Report (F(in)AR) 2026 point to a clear conclusion: Africa's challenges in freedom and prosperity are closely connected. Political institutions affect economic confidence; economic opportunity affects social stability; and security, public services and living conditions influence whether citizens can meaningfully exercise their freedoms. The strongest-performing countries in the report tend to perform relatively well across several of these areas at the same time, while countries facing the greatest difficulties often experience weaknesses across multiple dimensions.

F(in)AR therefore does not point to a single policy solution for the continent. Different countries and regions require different priorities. However, the evidence identifies several areas where governments, regional organisations, and continental institutions can take practical action.

Strengthen institutions before crises expose them

The first priority should be to build institutions that can function independent of individual political leaders. F(in)AR shows that countries with stronger political institutions generally have greater room for participation, more predictable economic environments, and stronger overall outcomes. At the same time, parts of the continent continue to experience political instability, military rule, weak checks on executive power and declining public trust.

Governments should therefore strengthen constitutional safeguards, independent oversight bodies, legislatures and courts. Judicial appointments should be transparent and based on professional merit, while courts should have sufficient security of tenure and institutional independence to make decisions without political pressure.

This is consistent with recent work by the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (International IDEA), which recommends stronger institutions capable of resisting political manipulation, greater judicial independence and stronger protections for civic space.

African governments should also strengthen accountability outside election periods. Parliamentary oversight, public procurement systems, anti-corruption institutions and access to government information should be treated as permanent parts of democratic governance rather than mechanisms activated only during political crises.

Turn Africa's youth population into productive employment

Africa's employment challenge is not simply about unemployment. F(in)AR shows that very high levels of self-employment in countries such as Chad, Sierra Leone, Madagascar and Nigeria can reflect entrepreneurial energy, but can also indicate that formal employment opportunities are insufficient.

Policy should therefore focus on productivity and the quality of work, not just the number of jobs announced. Governments should reduce the cost of starting and operating businesses, expand access to finance, improve electricity and transport infrastructure, strengthen digital connectivity and make it easier for small firms to move from informal to formal activity without imposing burdens that discourage them from growing.

Education and vocational training should also be connected more directly to actual labour-market demand. The World Bank argues that improving productivity across agriculture, household enterprises, and modern wage sectors is essential to addressing Africa's youth employment challenge.

Recent African Development Bank work similarly emphasises skills, private investment, entrepreneurship and access to finance as important parts of turning Africa's young population into an economic asset.

The policy goal should not be to push every young person toward formal employment. It should be to create an economy in which agriculture, small businesses, self-employment and formal wage jobs can all become more productive, secure and capable of generating rising incomes.

Make elections more credible, not simply more frequent

The FinAR results show improvements in electoral integrity in several countries, including Ghana, Morocco and Côte d'Ivoire. Ghana's electoral administration and dispute-resolution mechanisms are highlighted positively, but the wider picture remains fragile, with electoral manipulation and declining public trust continuing to affect parts of the continent.

The priority should therefore move beyond simply holding elections. Governments and electoral management bodies should ensure that electoral commissions have genuine operational independence, that voter registration is accessible and transparent, that political parties compete on a level playing field and that electoral disputes can be resolved quickly by independent courts.

African countries should also strengthen campaign-finance transparency, protect election observers and journalists, and publish election results in accessible and verifiable formats. Regional institutions should make democratic commitments enforceable. International IDEA has also called for stronger regional mechanisms, constitutional safeguards and accessible electoral justice systems.

Treat digital access as both an economic and political freedom

Digital connectivity has become central to economic participation, education, communication and civic life. F(in)AR finds that mobile technology is already contributing substantially to Africa's economy, yet affordability remains a major barrier and internet shutdowns continue to restrict access. The report records 30 shutdowns across 15 African countries.

Governments should commit to keeping the internet open, affordable and reliable, including during elections and periods of political unrest. Internet shutdowns should not be used as a routine tool for managing protests or political activity.
Cybercrime laws should target genuine criminal conduct without becoming broad instruments for suppressing criticism or journalism. Governments should also strengthen privacy protections and establish clear rules governing state surveillance and emerging technologies.

At the economic level, governments should reduce the cost of devices and data, expand broadband infrastructure and encourage competition among telecommunications providers. Connecting people is not enough; citizens must also be able to afford meaningful use of the internet.

Protect civic space, independent media and peaceful protest

Freedom of expression, association and assembly are essential for accountable governance. Governments should review laws affecting journalists, civil society organisations and public demonstrations to ensure that restrictions are necessary, proportionate and consistent with democratic principles.

Security agencies should receive clear guidance on managing peaceful protests, while allegations of excessive force should be investigated independently. Expanding civic space allows citizens to participate constructively in public life and provides governments with valuable feedback on policy performance.

Protect property rights and make it easier to do business

Secure property rights and predictable business regulations are critical for investment and economic growth. Governments should simplify business registration processes, reduce unnecessary licensing requirements and improve land registration systems.

Digital public services can help reduce administrative burdens and increase transparency. Stronger protection of property rights gives households and businesses greater confidence to invest, while a more competitive business environment can encourage innovation, entrepreneurship and job creation.

Make AfCFTA work through practical reforms

The benefits of continental integration will depend on implementation rather than agreements alone. Governments should reduce customs delays, simplify border procedures and remove non-tariff barriers that increase the cost of trade. Investment in transport corridors, logistics infrastructure and digital trade systems can help businesses access larger markets. Regional economic communities should also promote easier movement of workers, mutual recognition of qualifications and interoperable payment systems. These reforms would help translate AfCFTA into tangible economic opportunities for citizens and businesses.

Give young people a meaningful stake in government

Africa's youth are increasingly using protests, social media, community organisations and environmental campaigns to influence public policy. F(in)AR shows that this participation is expanding even as civic space remains restricted.

Governments should create formal channels through which young people can influence policy beyond elections. Youth councils, citizen consultations, participatory budgeting, digital consultation platforms and structured dialogue between governments and civil society can provide alternatives to street mobilisation when grievances emerge.

International IDEA's recent work also emphasises meaningful youth participation, civic education and political literacy, particularly for young and first-time voters. Young people should not be viewed only as beneficiaries of policy. They should be treated as participants in designing it.

Make prosperity about services, security and opportunity

F(in)AR's prosperity findings provide one of the report's clearest warnings. Improvements in some areas were outweighed by setbacks in employment, equality, healthcare access, and peace and stability. The report's prosperity results show that economic growth alone does not guarantee better living conditions.

Governments should therefore measure development by outcomes that citizens experience directly: access to healthcare, quality education, reliable electricity and transport, employment opportunities, personal security and the ability to improve one's economic position. Public investment should prioritise infrastructure and essential services that increase productivity while also reaching underserved communities.

Inequality should be treated as an economic policy issue as well as a social one. The World Bank argues that widening access to jobs and public services is one of Africa's strongest opportunities for reducing poverty and expanding growth. Growth becomes more meaningful when more people can participate in it.

Put peace and security at the centre of development policy

The FinAR data shows a strong connection between instability and weak prosperity. Conflict disrupts businesses, displaces communities and makes it harder for governments to provide basic services. The Institute for Economics and Peace identifies Sub-Saharan Africa as one of the world's least peaceful regions, with eight of the 20 least peaceful countries globally. Security policy should therefore be linked to economic and institutional development rather than treated as a separate policy area.

Governments should strengthen civilian institutions, improve local conflict-prevention mechanisms and address the economic pressures that contribute to instability. In conflict-affected countries, restoring basic security and functioning public institutions should come before expecting major improvements in investment, employment or public services. Regional organisations should strengthen early-warning systems and coordinate responses to political crises before instability becomes entrenched.

A coordinated African policy agenda

The central lesson of F(in)AR 2026 is that Africa does not need to choose between freedom and development. The evidence instead suggests that political rights, economic opportunity and prosperity should be treated as mutually reinforcing parts of development. For stronger-performing countries, the priority is to widen participation in existing gains through better jobs, infrastructure, private-sector growth and more inclusive public services. For countries facing democratic pressure, the priority is to rebuild institutional trust, protect civic freedoms and strengthen electoral and judicial systems. For fragile and conflict-affected states, restoring security, basic institutions and essential services must come first.

At the continental level, five priorities should guide the next phase of reform:

- First, build capable and accountable institutions. Governments must strengthen rule of law, judicial independence, electoral integrity, and public accountability.
- Second, expand economic opportunity. Countries should make it easier to start businesses, protect property, access finance, trade, and create productive employment.
- Third, invest in people. Education, healthcare, infrastructure and skills development must be treated as foundations of prosperity rather than secondary outcomes of economic growth.
- Fourth, keep Africa connected. Regional mobility, AfCFTA implementation, digital infrastructure, and open internet access should become central elements of economic and civic policy.
- Fifth, protect participation. Citizens must have meaningful opportunities to vote, organise, protest, access information, and influence public decisions without fear of repression.

The greatest opportunity presented by F(in)AR 2026 is therefore not simply identifying which countries rank highest or lowest. It is identifying what stronger-performing countries are doing well, where weaker countries face recurring barriers, and how those lessons can be adapted across different African contexts. African countries must create the confidence for investment, as economic opportunity will create productive livelihoods and public services will convert economic gains into better living conditions. Enhanced Security must then protect these gains. And citizens must have the freedom to participate in the systems that govern them.

The countries that make the most durable progress will be those that pursue all of these objectives together.

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